The Strumming Ladder

115 strumming patterns in 10 levels, each with the songs it is heard in

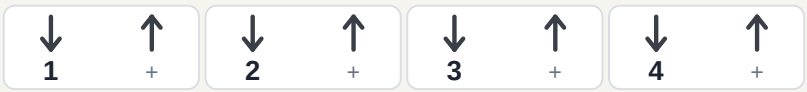
The one rule: the hand never stops

Your strumming hand swings like a pendulum, down and up, in time with the count. A pattern is a choice of which swings touch the strings and which pass by in the air. That is why the patterns are in this order: most patterns remove or add one or two strokes from a pattern you already know.

Quarter notes down on the number; the swing back up misses the strings



Eighth notes down on the number, up on the +



Sixteenth notes down on the number and +, up on e and a



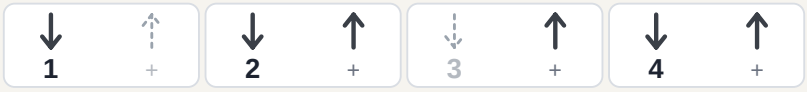
Triplets three to a beat, so beats 2 and 4 start on an up



Shuffle the middle count is left out: down, up on the a

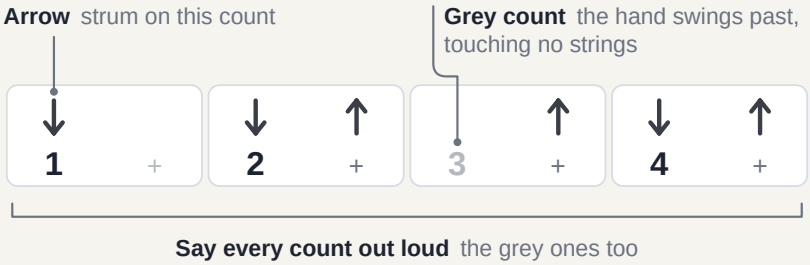


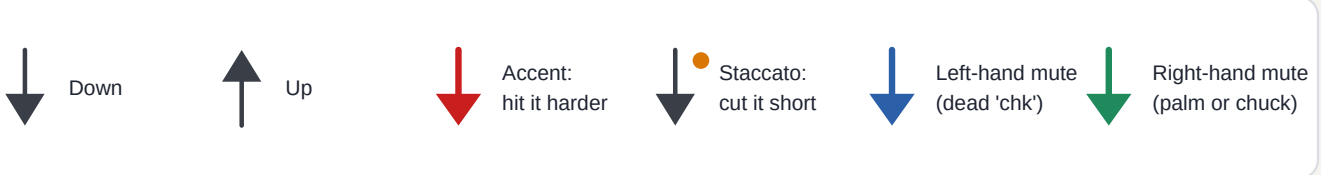
A pattern the eighth-note swings, two of them missing the strings



One bar in each feel. Blue arrows are triplet beats that start on an upstroke; dashed arrows are swings that miss the strings.

How to read the diagrams



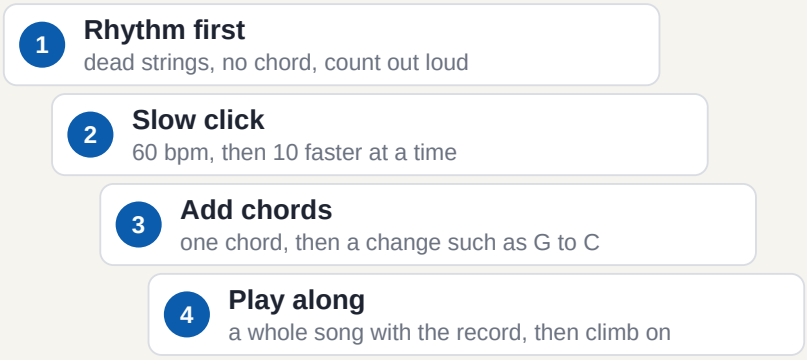


A **B** in place of an arrow means pick only the bass string of the chord.

The line of notation

Under each diagram the same bar is written in standard rhythm notation, for those who read it. A strum followed by missed counts is written as a longer note, or as tied notes, because the chord keeps ringing. Slash noteheads are strums, x noteheads are muted strums and a round notehead is a bass note. The time signature is left out: a bar has four beats unless the title says 6/8 or 3/4. A swung eighth-note pattern is written in 12/8, the way its diagram counts it; swung sixteenths are written straight.

How to climb



1. Rhythm first, no chord. Learn the strumming hand on its own. Rest the fretting hand lightly across all the strings, without pressing, so every strum gives a dead 'chk' and no notes. Strum the pattern like that while counting out loud. Add a chord only when the hand runs by itself.

2. Slow metronome. 60 bpm for eighth-note patterns, 50-60 bpm for sixteenth-note patterns. Move up about 10 bpm at a time.

3. One chord, then two. Loop the pattern on one chord for a minute, then over a change such as G to C. The pattern must not hiccup at the change.

4. Play it with the record. Put on one of the listed songs and strum along - on dead strings, as in step 1, if you do not know the chords. When you can hold the pattern through a whole song, climb to the next one.

The ladder at a glance

1	Quarter notes	patterns 1-5	
2	Straight eighth notes	patterns 6-22	
3	Compound time and waltz	patterns 23-27	
4	Syncopated eighth notes	patterns 28-47	
5	Triplets and shuffle	patterns 48-67	
6	Syncopated triplets	patterns 68-75	
7	Muting: left hand and right hand	patterns 76-83	
8	Straight sixteenth notes	patterns 84-97	
9	Syncopated sixteenth notes	patterns 98-110	
10	Swung sixteenths	patterns 111-115	

A note from the author. I am not a guitar teacher. I am a student, and I made these materials for my own practice. I am sharing them in case they are useful to someone else, but please do not take them too seriously: I have no experience of teaching anyone but myself.

Index of patterns

Click a line to jump to it. The number on the right is the page.

1 Quarter notes 4

1 Half notes: two strums 4
2 Half notes, then one long strum 4
3 Half notes, then a step 4
4 Four on the floor 4
5 Quarters with a pickup 5

2 Straight eighth notes 6

6 Constant down-up 6
7 Constant down-up, then a breat... 6
8 Three upstrokes 6
9 Down, down-up 6
10 Plain bar, busy bar 7
11 Two upstrokes 7
12 Quarters, then eighths 7
13 Pickup bar, busy bar 7
14 Down-up on beat 2 only 7
15 Driving eighths, all down 8
16 Downstroke drive with gaps 8
17 Boom-chick: bass, strum 8
18 Boom-chicka: bass, down-up 8
19 Bass notes with a run of strums 8
20 Bass, strum, then a run 8
21 Strum, bass, strum 9
22 Strum and bass in turns 9

3 Compound time and waltz 10

23 Six-eight: six downstrokes 10
24 Six-eight with gaps 10
25 Six-eight with upstrokes 10
26 Waltz strum (3/4) 10
27 Waltz with a push, then the walt... 11

4 Syncopated eighth notes 12

28 Miss beat 3 12
29 Miss beat 2 12
30 Old Faithful: down, down-up, up-... 12
31 Down, down-up, then Old Faithful 12
32 Two upstrokes, then Old Faithful 13
33 Old Faithful, cut short 13
34 Miss beat 4 13
35 The long pause 13
36 One push 13
37 Push and answer 14
38 Tresillo accents 14
39 Off-beats after the one 14
40 Two upstrokes, tied over 14
41 Push across the bar line 14
42 Push, then a gap 15
43 Down, down-up, tied over 15
44 Old Faithful, tied over 15
45 Two upstrokes into Old Faithful,... 15
46 The long pause, tied over 16
47 Miss beat 4, tied over 16

5 Triplets and shuffle 17

48 Triplets, all downstrokes 17
49 Downstroke triplets, one count out 17
50 Downstroke triplets with a rest 17
51 Slow triplets: one strum, then thr... 17
52 Triplets, alternating 18
53 Alternating triplets, one strum out 18
54 Alternating triplets, two strums out 18
55 Alternating triplets, beat 1 held 18
56 One strum, then a triplet 18
57 The shuffle 18
58 Shuffle with a long first beat 19
59 Down, down-up, swung 19
60 Plain bar, busy bar, swung 19
61 Down, down-up swung, then a s... 19
62 Shuffle with space 19
63 Swung quarters with a pickup 20
64 Swung pickup bar, then shuffle... 20
65 Shuffle with space, then the ans... 20
66 Swung bass-and-strum 20
67 Swung boom-chicka 20

6 Syncopated triplets 21

68 Shuffle, then miss beat 3 21
69 Miss beat 3, swung 21
70 Old Faithful, swung 21
71 Swung quarters, then Old Faithf... 22
72 Swung pickup bar, then Old Fait... 22
73 The long pause, swung 22
74 Bass note, then Old Faithful swu... 22
75 Old Faithful swung, tied over 22

7 Muting: left hand and right hand 23

76 Left-hand mute: ring, then choke 23
77 Strum and scratch 23
78 Staccato: strum and cut 23
79 Staccato off-beats 23
80 Palm mute 24
81 The chuck (Old Faithful with a sl... 24
82 Chucks on 2 and 4, then the chu... 24
83 One chuck, then none 24

8 Straight sixteenth notes 25

84 The sixteenth engine 25
85 Engine with a breath 25
86 Gallop into a full beat 25
87 The gallop 25
88 Indie-rock strum 26
89 Eighths with a pickup 26
90 Slow strum with a flick 26
91 Quarter notes with a flick 26
92 Gallop with a breath 26
93 Indie-rock strum, then without th... 27
94 Indie-rock strum, with a run 27
95 Indie-rock strum, then a long run 27
96 Slow strum with a flick, with a run 27
97 Slow strum with a flick, then eig... 28

9 Syncopated sixteenth notes 29

98 Old Faithful, double time 29
99 The long pause, double time 29
100 Slow start, skip beat 3 29
101 Slow strum with a flick, then skip... 29
102 Skip beat 3 30
103 Fill beat 3, then skip it 30
104 Skip beat 3, busy ending 30
105 Skip beat 3, two endings 30
106 Slow start, busy ending 30
107 The Bo Diddley beat 31
108 Modern acoustic strum 31
109 Funk sixteenths with scratches 31
110 Skip beat 3, tied over 31

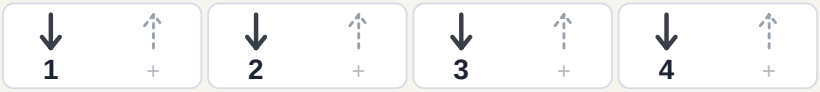
10 Swung sixteenths 32

111 The gallop, swung 32
112 Swung sixteenths 32
113 Bass notes and a swung flick 32
114 Old Faithful, double time and sw... 32
115 Swung chucks 32

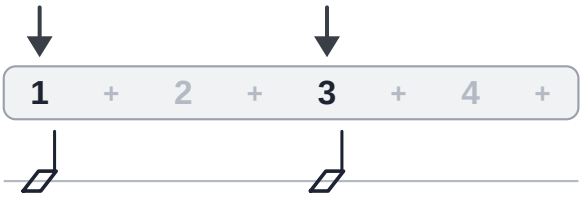
Level 1 - Quarter notes

One strum per beat, or fewer. The job here is a steady hand and clean chord changes - nothing else.

One strum per beat the swing back up misses the strings



1 Half notes: two strums

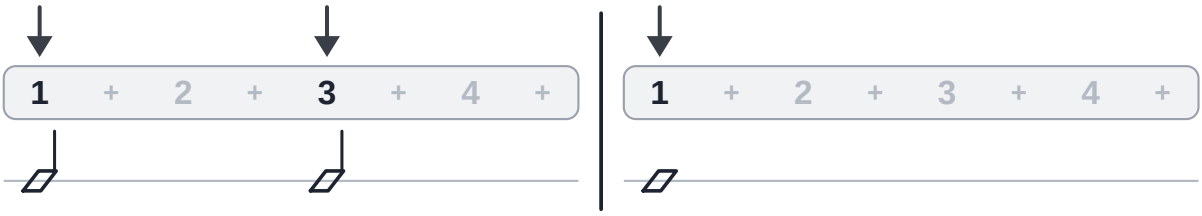


HEAR IT IN

When We Were Young – Adele (intro) • Sweet Caroline – Neil Diamond (intro) • Sign of the Times – Harry Styles (chorus)

One strum on beat 1, one on beat 3, and let each ring for two beats. Count all four beats out loud. Slow ballads often start like this before the full strum comes in.

2 Half notes, then one long strum

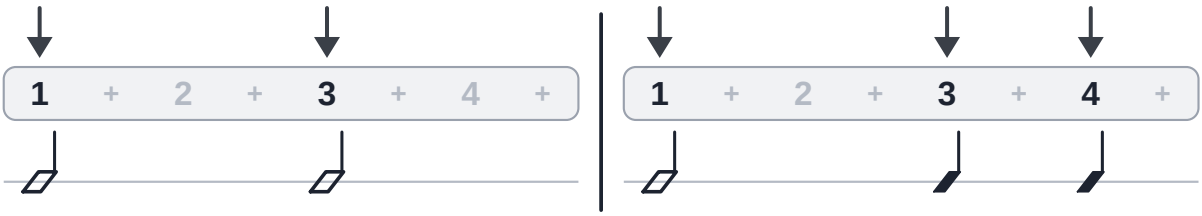


HEAR IT IN

One Call Away – Charlie Puth (intro) • Supermarket Flowers – Ed Sheeran (verse, first two of four bars)

The easiest two-bar pattern: two strums in the first bar, one in the second that rings for all four beats. Keep counting through the long strum.

3 Half notes, then a step

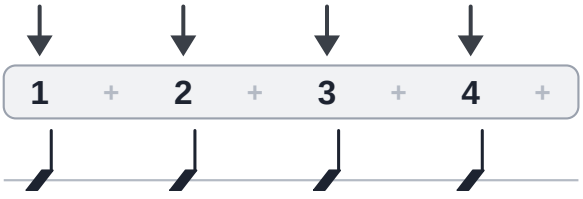


HEAR IT IN

Let It Go – Idina Menzel (from Frozen; verse, slow)

Two strums per bar, with one extra strum on beat 4 of the second bar to lead back to the start.

4 Four on the floor

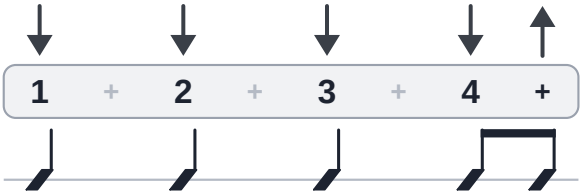


HEAR IT IN

Say Something – A Great Big World • Jar of Hearts – Christina Perri (chorus)

All downstrokes, one per beat. Let the hand rise silently on each '+' - that silent lift is the upstroke you will add later.

5 Quarters with a pickup



HEAR IT IN

Comfortably Numb – Pink Floyd • Every Rose Has Its Thorn – Poison

Your first upstroke: a light flick on the '+' of 4 that pushes into the next bar. Later, try hitting just the bass string on beat 2.

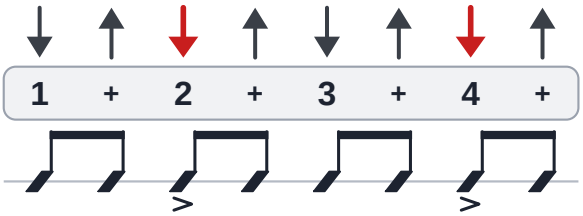
Level 2 - Straight eighth notes

Two slots per beat: '1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +'. Downstrokes land on the numbers, upstrokes on the '+'. The level starts with every slot played and then takes upstrokes away; the all-downstroke and bass-note patterns come after. No upstroke is left hanging over a missing beat yet: that is syncopation, and it starts in level 4.

Two counts per beat down on the number, up on the +



6 Constant down-up *aka alternate strumming*

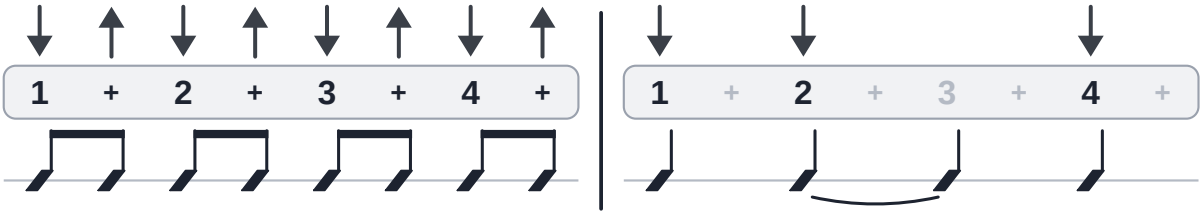


HEAR IT IN

Sweet Home Alabama – Lynyrd Skynyrd • White Winter Hymnal – Fleet Foxes • Songbird – Oasis • Cheerleader – OMI • Johnny B. Goode – Chuck Berry • Mr. Tambourine Man – Bob Dylan

The hand's natural motion with nothing left out: down on every number, up on every '+'. The eight patterns after it are this one with strokes removed. Accent beats 2 and 4 slightly so it grooves instead of sounding like a machine.

7 Constant down-up, then a breather

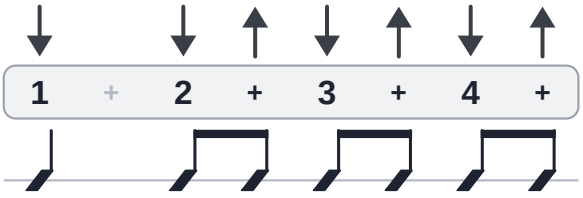


HEAR IT IN

Happier – Ed Sheeran

A full bar of down-up, then a bar of three slow strums on beats 1, 2 and 4. The hand keeps the same motion in both bars; in the second it mostly misses.

8 Three upstrokes

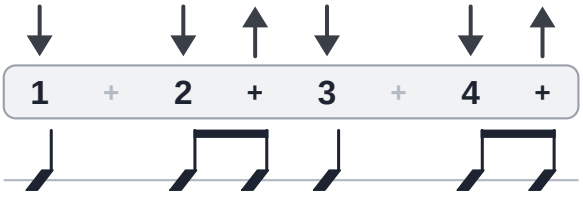


HEAR IT IN

Love Story – Taylor Swift • Last Christmas – Wham! • In My Life – The Beatles • The Man Who Can't Be Moved – The Script

Constant down-up with one stroke removed: the hand misses the strings on the '+' of 1. The long first beat makes the bar breathe.

9 Down, down-up

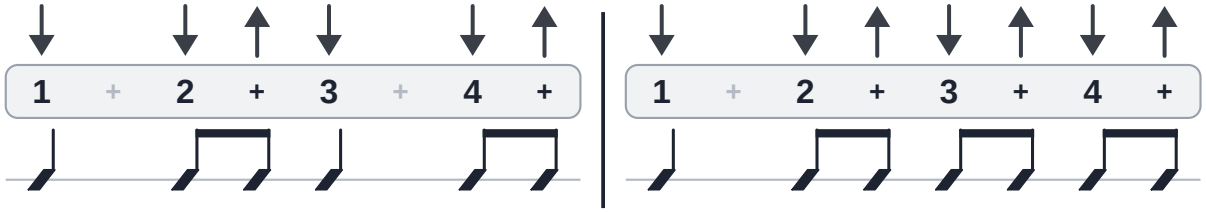


HEAR IT IN

Let It Be – The Beatles • American Pie – Don McLean • Over My Head (Cable Car) – The Fray • She's Not There – The Zombies

A two-beat cell (down, down-up) played twice. Works on almost any slow song.

10 Plain bar, busy bar

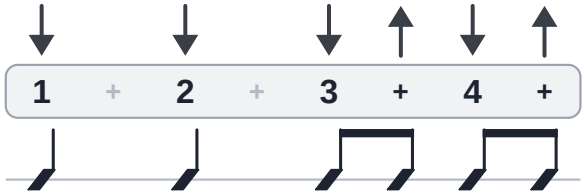


HEAR IT IN

The Sound of Silence – Simon & Garfunkel • Wonderful Tonight – Eric Clapton • Grenade – Bruno Mars (verse)

Many songs repeat a strum every two bars, not every bar. This one is the previous pattern followed by pattern 8. The second bar fills the gap after beat 3, which gives the pair a sense of question and answer.

11 Two upstrokes

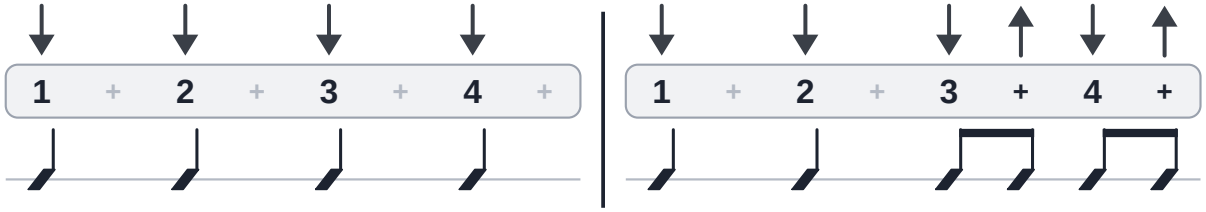


HEAR IT IN

Straight and Narrow – Teenage Fanclub • Patience – Guns N' Roses • California Stars – Billy Bragg and Wilco • Lost in My Mind – The Head and the Heart

Now the '+' of 1 and the '+' of 2 are both missed: quarter notes in the first half of the bar, eighths in the second half.

12 Quarters, then eighths

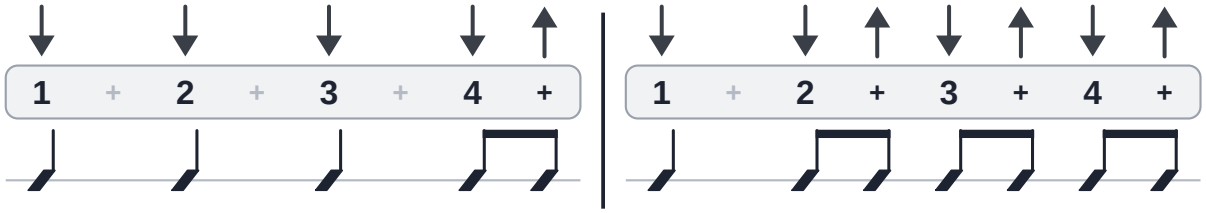


HEAR IT IN

Misery Business – Paramore

Pattern 4, then the previous pattern: a bar of four downstrokes, then a bar that breaks into down-ups at the end. The contrast between the two bars is the hook.

13 Pickup bar, busy bar

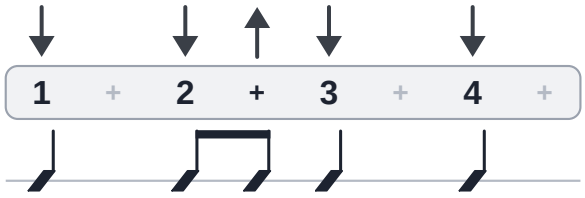


HEAR IT IN

Vampire – Olivia Rodrigo (first chorus)

Pattern 5, then pattern 8. The single upstroke at the end of bar 1 announces the busier bar.

14 Down-up on beat 2 only

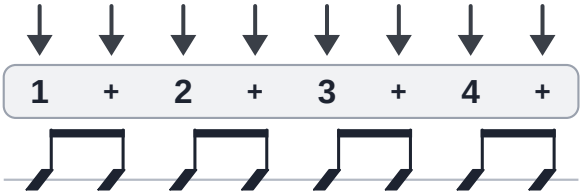


HEAR IT IN

Crazy – Gnarls Barkley • Sweet Child O' Mine – Guns N' Roses (acoustic arrangement)

Four downstrokes with a single upstroke after beat 2. A good test of control: the hand must miss the strings on three of its four upswings.

15 Driving eighths, all down

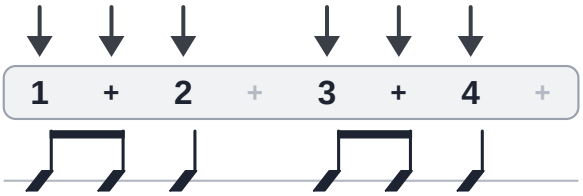


HEAR IT IN

Free Fallin' – Tom Petty • Chasing Cars – Snow Patrol • Get Back – The Beatles • Yellow – Coldplay • Times Like These – Foo Fighters • Walk on the Wild Side – Lou Reed

Eight downstrokes. This breaks the down/up rule on purpose: the hand has to come back up without touching the strings twice as often, which gives the pumping rock sound. Keep the wrist loose.

16 Downstroke drive with gaps
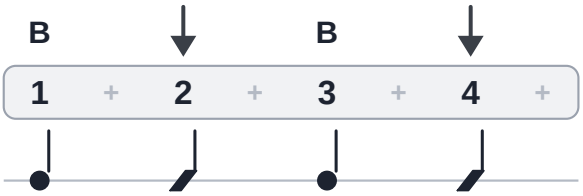


HEAR IT IN

I Love Rock 'n' Roll – Joan Jett and the Blackhearts • Highway to Hell – AC/DC

All downstrokes again, but leave the '+' of 2 and the '+' of 4 empty. The gaps are what make the riff punch - classic power-chord rock.

17 Boom-chick: bass, strum

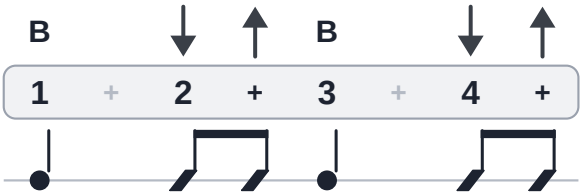


HEAR IT IN

Hey There Delilah – Plain White T's • I Hear Them All – Old Crow Medicine Show

Also called: boom-chuck, alternating bass. B = pick only the bass string of the chord (the lowest note you would strum). Bass on 1 and 3, a downstroke on the higher strings on 2 and 4. The simplest country and folk accompaniment.

18 Boom-chicka: bass, down-up

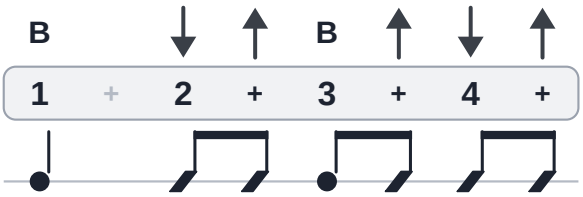


HEAR IT IN

Folsom Prison Blues – Johnny Cash • Ring of Fire – Johnny Cash • Friend of the Devil – Grateful Dead • I Will Follow You Into the Dark – Death Cab for Cutie • New Slang – The Shins

Also called: Carter strum, country strum. The boom-chick with an upstroke added after each strum. This is pattern 9 with a bass note in place of the first strum - the country and folk sound.

19 Bass notes with a run of strums

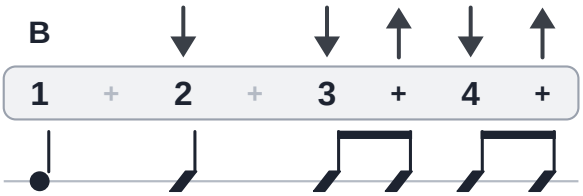


HEAR IT IN

Me and Bobby McGee – Kris Kristofferson • Sweet Dreams (Are Made of This) – Eurythmics

Boom-chicka in the first half of the bar; in the second half the bass note is followed by three strums, up-down-up.

20 Bass, strum, then a run

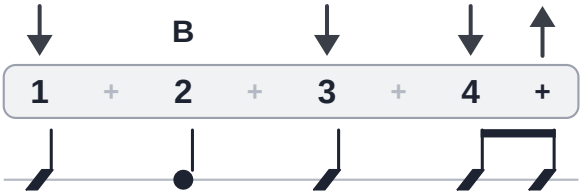


HEAR IT IN

Take Me Home, Country Roads – John Denver • Blowin' in the Wind – Bob Dylan • Should I Stay or Should I Go – The Clash • Closer to Fine – Indigo Girls • It's the End of the World as We Know It – R.E.M.

One bass note on beat 1, a strum on 2, then straight down-up eighths through beats 3 and 4. A campfire favourite: it sounds full but leaves the first half of the bar open for the singer.

21 Strum, bass, strum

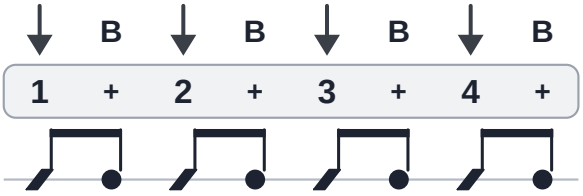


HEAR IT IN

Fix You – Coldplay • The First Cut Is the Deepest – Sheryl Crow • Savin' Me – Nickelback

The bass note moves to beat 2, between two full strums. Gentle and spacious, with one upstroke at the end to lead into the next bar.

22 Strum and bass in turns



HEAR IT IN

Imagine – John Lennon • Beautiful – Christina Aguilera • Sunshine (Go Away Today) – Jonathan Edwards

Downstroke on every beat, bass note on every '+'. It imitates a piano: chord in the right hand, single notes in the left.

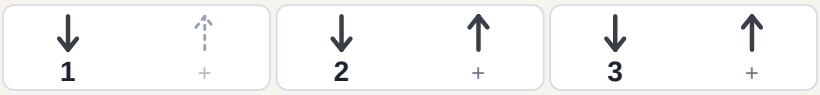
Level 3 - Compound time and waltz

A change of count, not of difficulty. Until now every beat split into two; in 6/8 it splits into three, and in 3/4 the bar has three beats. Apart from the last pattern, the strumming is even and unsyncopated, so it is no harder than level 2 - it only needs a new way of counting.

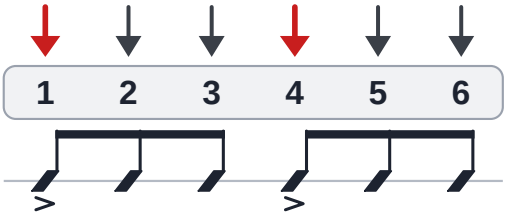
6/8 two beats of three: lean on 1 and 4



3/4 three beats of two: the waltz strum



23 Six-eight: six downstrokes *6/8 time*

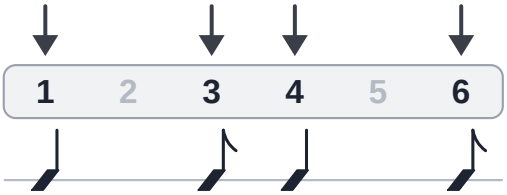


HEAR IT IN

House of the Rising Sun – The Animals • Until I Found You – Stephen Sanchez (chorus)

Compound time: two beats per bar, each made of three. Six downstrokes, leaning on 1 and 4. Count 'ONE two three FOUR five six'.

24 Six-eight with gaps *6/8 time*

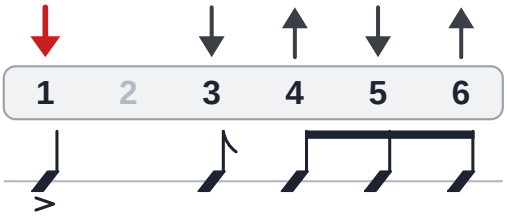


HEAR IT IN

Perfect – Ed Sheeran (chorus) • Until I Found You – Stephen Sanchez (verse)

Leave out counts 2 and 5. Each half of the bar becomes long-short: the lilting ballad feel.

25 Six-eight with upstrokes *6/8 time*

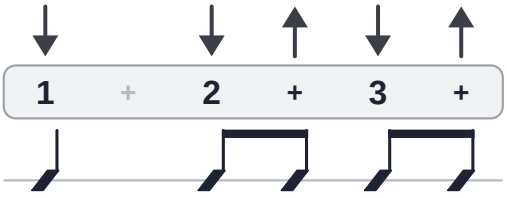


HEAR IT IN

Hallelujah – Jeff Buckley • All I Want – Kodaline

The hand alternates down-up on the six counts. Miss count 2, play everything else. A common strummed 6/8 pattern.

26 Waltz strum (3/4) *3/4 time*

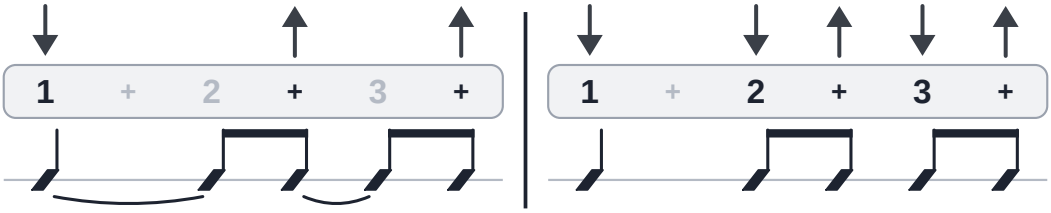


HEAR IT IN

Norwegian Wood – The Beatles • Annie's Song – John Denver • Iris – Goo Goo Dolls • Nothingman – Pearl Jam

Three beats per bar, each split in two - simple time, not compound, but it sits here because the bar counts in three. Down on 1, then down-up, down-up.

27 Waltz with a push, then the waltz strum *3/4 time*



HEAR IT IN

Riverwide – Sheryl Crow

The only two-bar pattern in three found in the song data, and harder than the rest of this level: bar 1 strums beat 1 and then only the '+' of 2 and of 3, so beats 2 and 3 are skipped. Bar 2 is the plain waltz strum. Come back to it after level 4 if the skipped beats throw you.

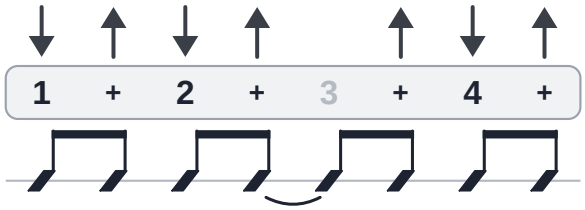
Level 4 - Syncopated eighth notes

Syncopation starts when you skip a downstroke ON a beat: the hand still goes down, but misses the strings. An upstroke with no downstroke after it is the sound of syncopation.

Skip a beat the down on 3 misses; the up before it hangs over



28 Miss beat 3

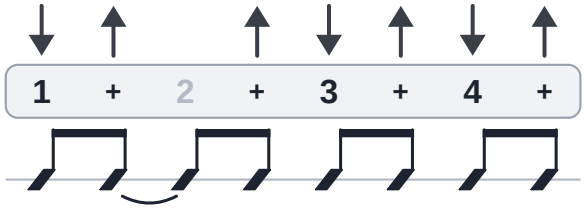


HEAR IT IN

This Mess We're In – PJ Harvey feat. Thom Yorke

Constant down-up, but the hand ghosts past the strings on beat 3. Say '3' out loud while you miss it.

29 Miss beat 2

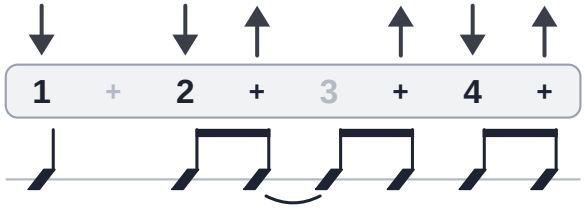


HEAR IT IN

(What's So Funny 'Bout) Peace, Love and Understanding – Elvis Costello

The same idea one beat earlier: the upstroke after beat 1 hangs over beat 2. It feels like the bar trips forward at the start.

30 Old Faithful: down, down-up, up-down-up

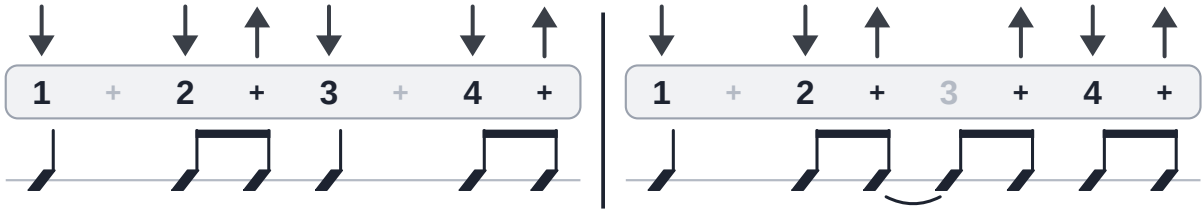


HEAR IT IN

Brown Eyed Girl – Van Morrison • Stand By Me – Ben E. King • How to Save a Life – The Fray • Hey Ya! – OutKast • Patience – Guns N' Roses

Also called: folk strum, island strum. The most used strum in pop and rock - if you learn one pattern from this booklet, make it this one.

31 Down, down-up, then Old Faithful

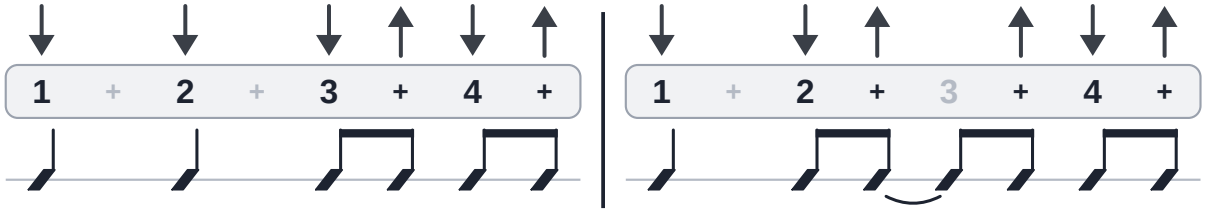


HEAR IT IN

As It Was – Harry Styles

A plain bar from level 2, then Old Faithful. Only the second bar skips beat 3, so the plain bar gives you time to recover.

32 Two upstrokes, then Old Faithful

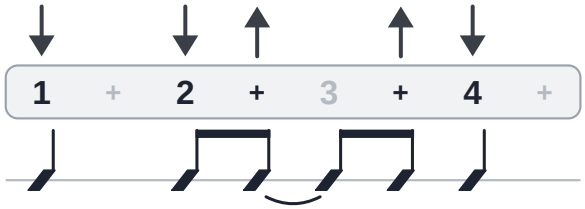


HEAR IT IN

Peaceful Easy Feeling – Eagles

The same idea with pattern 11 as the plain bar.

33 Old Faithful, cut short

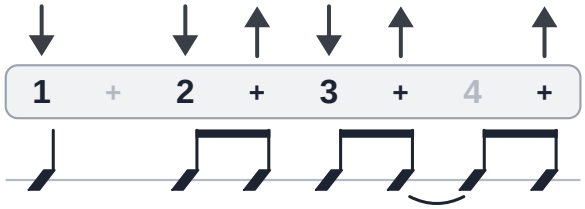


HEAR IT IN

Warning Sign – Coldplay (bar 1 of a two-bar pattern) • Desire – U2 (bar 1 of a two-bar pattern) • All of Me – John Legend (chorus)

Old Faithful without its last upstroke. Ending on the downstroke of beat 4 leaves a breath before the next bar - useful when the chord changes on beat 1.

34 Miss beat 4

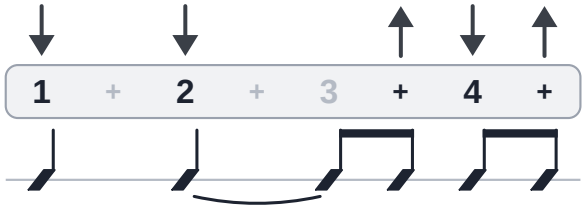


HEAR IT IN

Shallow – Lady Gaga and Bradley Cooper (one bar strummed, the next left to ring) • Losing My Religion – R.E.M. (intro, bar 1; both bars are pattern 47) • She Will Be Loved – Maroon 5 (intro and verse, bar 1 of a two-bar pattern)

Straight through beat 3, then the upstroke after 3 hangs over beat 4 and the last upstroke pulls you into the next bar.

35 The long pause

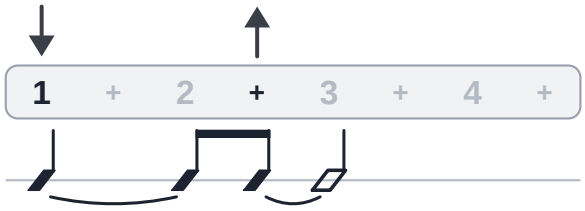


HEAR IT IN

Riptide – Vance Joy (intro and verse) • Lay Down Sally – Eric Clapton • Radioactive – Imagine Dragons • Little Talks – Of Monsters and Men (chorus) • The A Team – Ed Sheeran (intro, bar 1 of a two-bar pattern) • First Day of My Life – Bright Eyes

Two strums, a long gap across beat 3, then a quick up-down-up. In country and folk, play only the bass note on beat 1 (the 'train beat').

36 One push

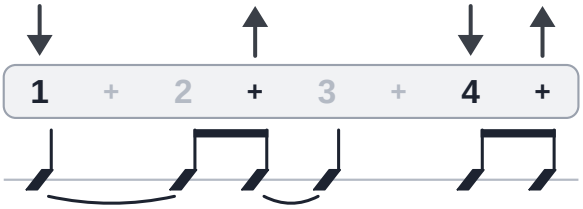


HEAR IT IN

Sweet Child O' Mine – Guns N' Roses (acoustic arrangement) • Don't Stop Believin' – Journey (chorus)

Just two strums: down on 1, then an upstroke on the '+' of 2 that rings across beats 3 and 4. Keep the hand swinging through the silence so the next bar starts in time.

37 Push and answer

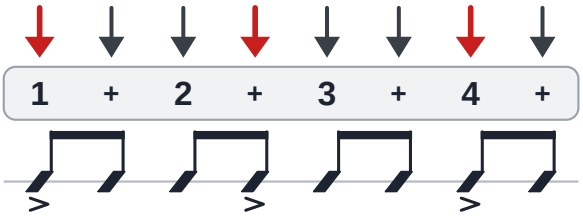


HEAR IT IN

Is She Really Going Out with Him? – Joe Jackson

The push from the previous pattern, answered by a down-up on beat 4. The strums fall in a 3 + 3 + 2 grouping - the tresillo, which the next pattern makes with accents instead of gaps.

38 Tresillo accents *aka 3 + 3 + 2, the 'Clocks' rhythm*

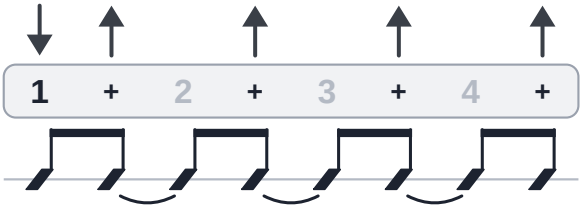


HEAR IT IN

Clocks – Coldplay • Glycerine – Bush • Downtown Train – Tom Waits

Eight even downstrokes, but lean hard on 1, the '+' of 2, and 4. The accents group the eighths 3 + 3 + 2 - the tresillo, a rhythm that came into pop from Cuban music. The hand plays straight; only the accents are syncopated.

39 Off-beats after the one

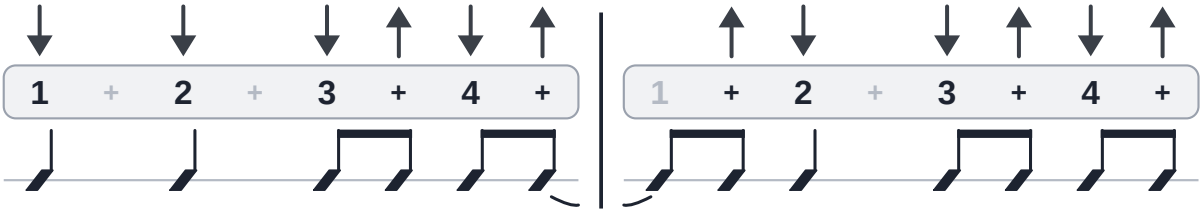


HEAR IT IN

Stitches – Shawn Mendes (intro and verse) • Amsterdam – Guster (bar 1 of a two-bar pattern)

Beat 1 is the only beat you hit. After it, every strum is an upstroke on a '+'. Tap your foot hard on 2, 3 and 4 - they are silent in the hand.

40 Two upstrokes, tied over

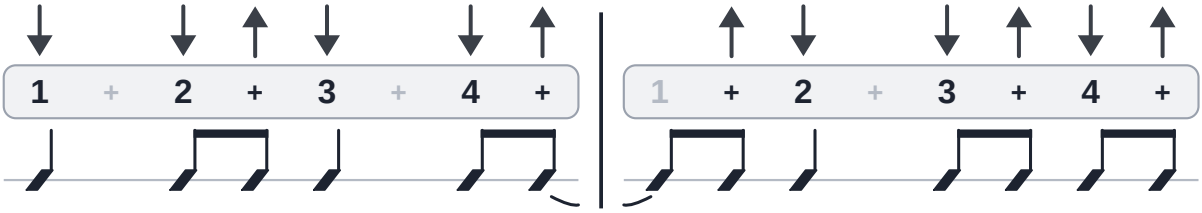


HEAR IT IN

Friday I'm in Love – The Cure • My Sweet Lord – George Harrison • Welcome to Paradise – Green Day • Lovesong – The Cure

A push across the bar line, the one thing a single bar cannot show. Bar 1 is pattern 11; its last upstroke rings over beat 1 of bar 2, which you skip. Count '1' out loud anyway and come back in on the '+' of 1. The most common two-bar strum in the song data.

41 Push across the bar line

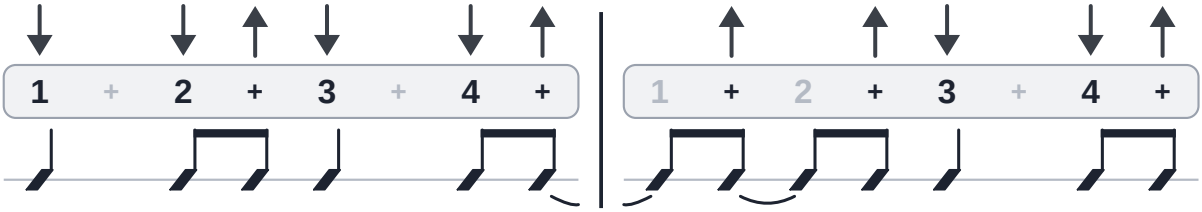


HEAR IT IN

Patience – Guns N' Roses

The same push as the previous pattern, starting from pattern 9: the last upstroke of bar 1 rings over beat 1 of bar 2, which you skip. This is syncopation stretched over two bars.

42 Push, then a gap

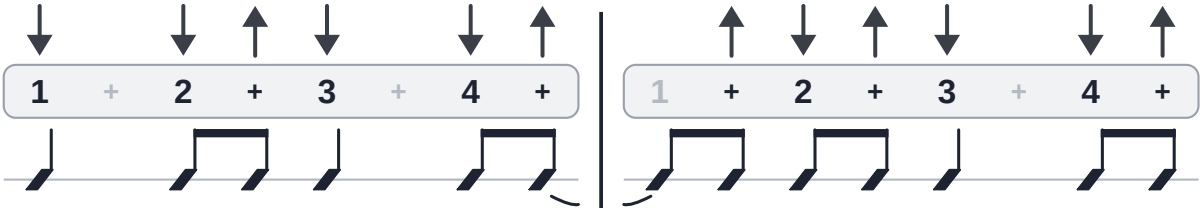


HEAR IT IN

Island in the Sun – Weezer

Bar 1 as in the previous pattern. Bar 2 skips beats 1 and 2 and plays only the '+' after each: two upstrokes in a row before the downstroke on 3.

43 Down, down-up, tied over

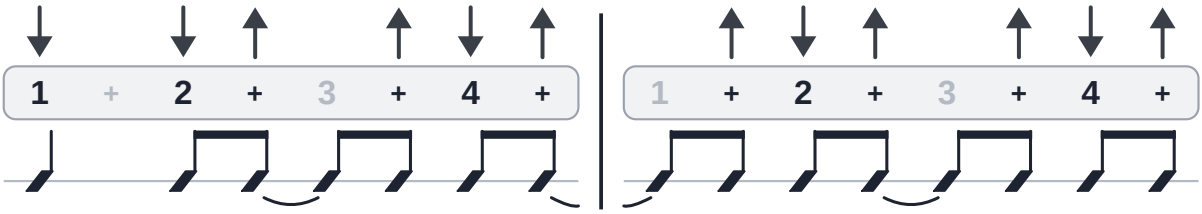


HEAR IT IN

Tears in Heaven – Eric Clapton (variation) • Ain't No Mountain High Enough – Marvin Gaye and Tammi Terrell

Bar 2 is bar 1 with its first downstroke missing and an upstroke on the '+' of 1 and of 2.

44 Old Faithful, tied over

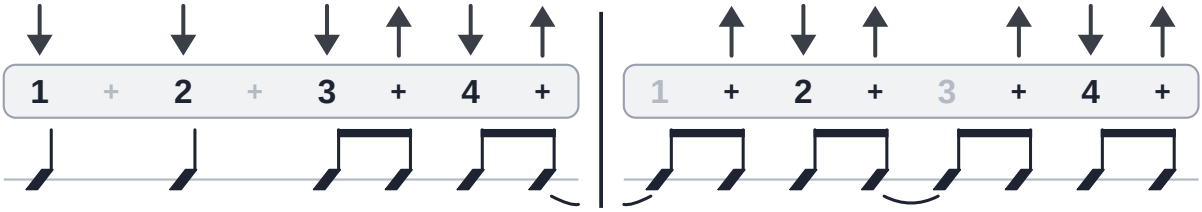


HEAR IT IN

Times Like These – Foo Fighters (verses) • Journey to the End of the East Bay – Rancid

Old Faithful in both bars, but the second starts on the '+' of 1: beat 3 is skipped in each bar and so is the downbeat of bar 2.

45 Two upstrokes into Old Faithful, tied over

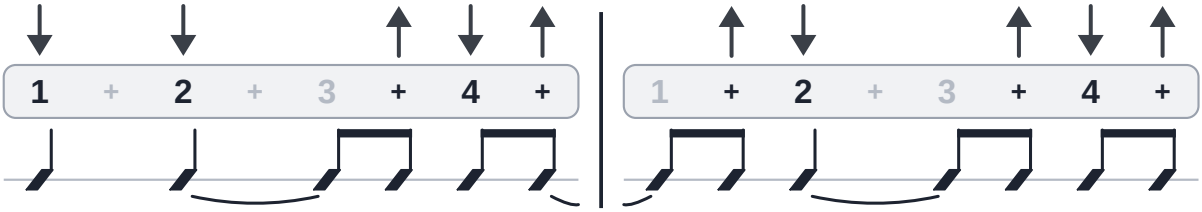


HEAR IT IN

Just Like Heaven – The Cure • Minsan – Eraserheads

Bar 1 of 'Two upstrokes, tied over' with bar 2 of the previous pattern.

46 The long pause, tied over

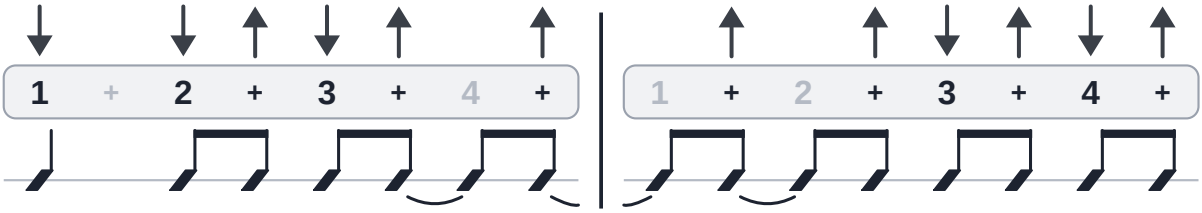


HEAR IT IN

California Stars – Billy Bragg and Wilco

Pattern 35 with its first downstroke missing in the second bar. The up-down-up at the end of bar 1 leads straight into the '+' of 1.

47 Miss beat 4, tied over



HEAR IT IN

Losing My Religion – R.E.M. (intro)

Bar 1 skips beat 4; its last upstroke carries across the bar line, and bar 2 skips beats 1 and 2. The famous mandolin-like drive of the intro below.

Level 5 - Triplets and shuffle

Three even strums per beat: count '1 + a 2 + a 3 + a 4 + a'. The patterns start with every count played, first all downstrokes and then alternating, and thin them out a strum or two at a time. Then the middle count of every beat is left out. That gap is the shuffle, or swing: the long-short feel of blues, rock and roll and a great deal of folk. The shuffle patterns thin out the same way. Almost every beat is still played (one two-bar pattern stops a beat early), so syncopation waits for the next level.

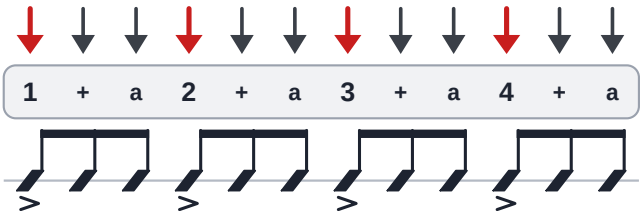
Triplets three even counts per beat



Shuffle the middle count left out: long-short



48 Triplets, all downstrokes *12/8 time*

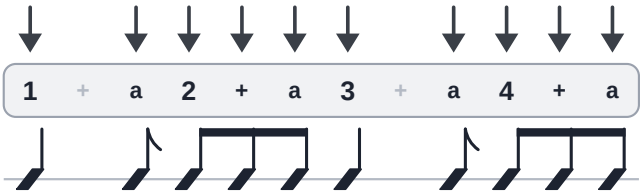


HEAR IT IN

You Are the Reason – Calum Scott (intro and verse) • Everybody Hurts – R.E.M.

Start here: twelve even downstrokes, leaning on the first of each three. Only practical at slow tempos, which is exactly where it is used: slow ballads.

49 Downstroke triplets, one count out *12/8 time*

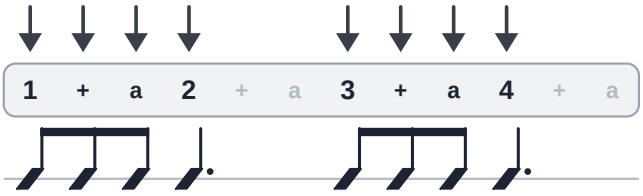


HEAR IT IN

We Belong Together – Ritchie Valens

The same downstrokes with the '+' of beats 1 and 3 left out, so those two beats get a longer first strum. Keep counting the missing '+'.

50 Downstroke triplets with a rest *12/8 time*

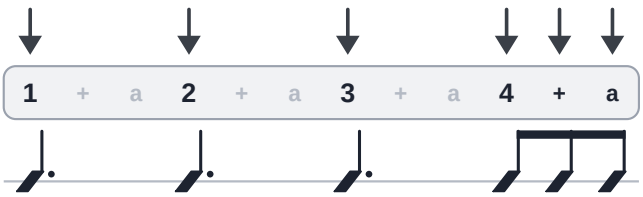


HEAR IT IN

Put Your Head on My Shoulder – Paul Anka (chorus) • Panalangin – APO Hiking Society

A full triplet on beats 1 and 3, one strum on beats 2 and 4 that rings for the rest of the beat. The doo-wop ballad strum.

51 Slow triplets: one strum, then three *12/8 time*

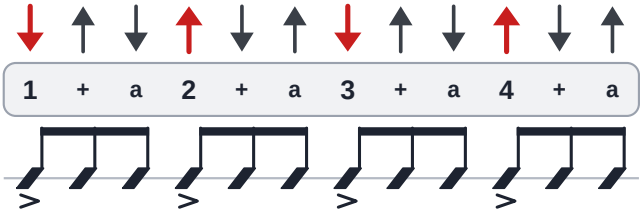


HEAR IT IN

Perfect – Ed Sheeran (pre-chorus)

The triplet is now left only on beat 4: one strum on beats 1, 2 and 3, then all three counts of beat 4 to push into the next bar. This is the 12/8 slow-dance feel. Count every '+' and 'a' out loud even where you do not strum.

52 Triplets, alternating *12/8 time*

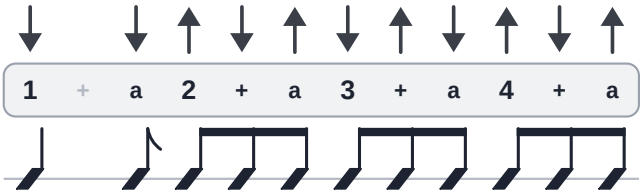


HEAR IT IN

All My Loving – The Beatles

Strict down-up alternation through all twelve counts. Because three is odd, beats 2 and 4 start on an upstroke - that is the whole difficulty, so stay on this pattern until it is comfortable. The next four patterns take one strum away at a time. Accent the first of each three whichever direction it falls.

53 Alternating triplets, one strum out *12/8 time*

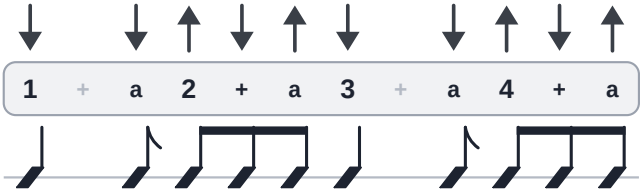


HEAR IT IN

Practice pattern – the first step from full triplets towards the patterns with gaps

The alternating triplets with a single strum missing: the '+' of beat 1. The hand still makes the upward move there, it just misses the strings.

54 Alternating triplets, two strums out *12/8 time*

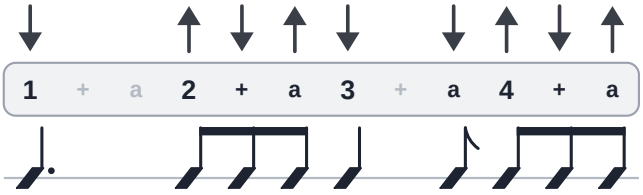


HEAR IT IN

Before You Go – Lewis Capaldi • O Come to the Altar – Elevation Worship • Hallelujah – Jeff Buckley

Now the '+' of beat 3 goes too, so both halves of the bar are the same: down, (miss), down, up-down-up.

55 Alternating triplets, beat 1 held *12/8 time*

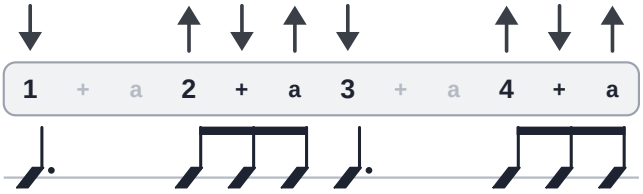


HEAR IT IN

Practice pattern – one strum away from the next pattern

The 'a' of beat 1 goes as well: beat 1 is one long strum, and beat 2 comes in on an upstroke after two silent counts. Beat 3 stays as in the previous pattern.

56 One strum, then a triplet *12/8 time*

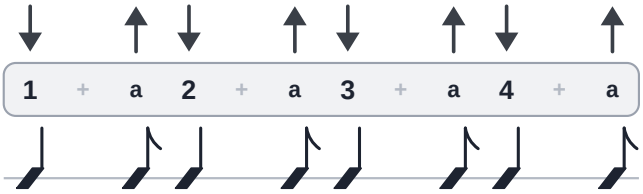


HEAR IT IN

Heather – Conan Gray • Reckless Love – Cory Asbury

A held strum on beats 1 and 3, a full triplet on beats 2 and 4. The last strum to go is the 'a' of beat 3. The triplets still start with an upstroke; the hand keeps swinging through the gaps.

57 The shuffle *aka swung eighths - swing feel*

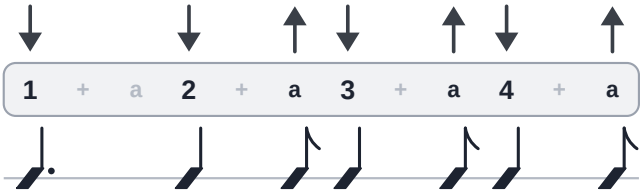


HEAR IT IN

Tush – ZZ Top • La Grange – ZZ Top • Pride and Joy – Stevie Ray Vaughan • Hallelujah – Leonard Cohen • You've Got a Friend in Me – Randy Newman

A triplet with the middle count left out: down on the beat, up on the 'a'. The hand is back to plain down-up, but long-short instead of even. From here on the diagrams keep the triplet count so you can see the gap.

58 Shuffle with a long first beat *swing feel*

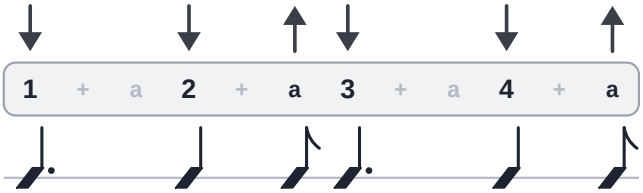


HEAR IT IN

Layla (Unplugged) – Eric Clapton (verse) • Don't Be Cruel – Elvis Presley • Big Iron – Marty Robbins • Lucky – Jason Mraz (chorus)

The shuffle with one upstroke left out, the 'a' of beat 1. Everything else is the same.

59 Down, down-up, swung *swing feel*

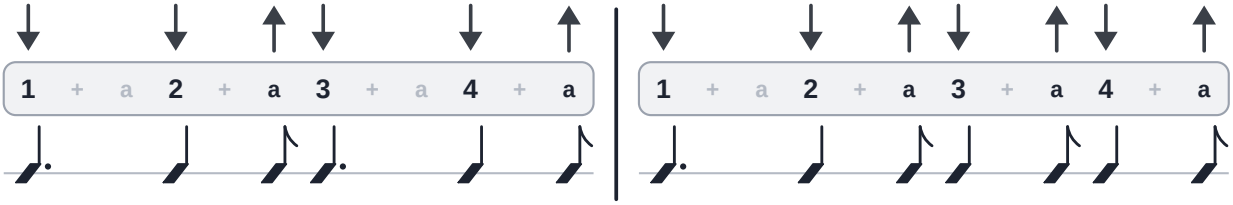


HEAR IT IN

What a Wonderful World – Louis Armstrong (verse) • Happier Than Ever – Billie Eilish (verse) • With a Little Help from My Friends – The Beatles

The previous pattern with the 'a' of beat 3 left out as well: a long strum, then a shuffled down-up, twice per bar. The most common gentle swing accompaniment.

60 Plain bar, busy bar, swung *swing feel*

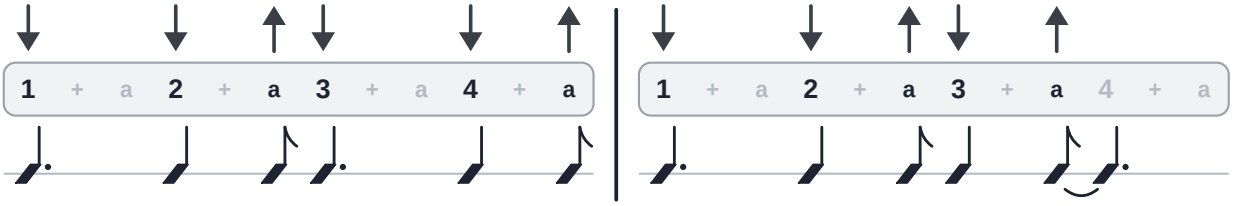


HEAR IT IN

With a Little Help from My Friends – The Beatles • Holiday – Green Day

Pattern 10 with a shuffle feel: the previous pattern, then pattern 58.

61 Down, down-up swung, then a stop *swing feel*

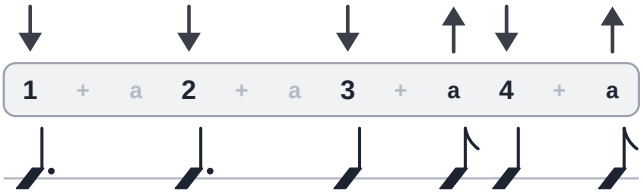


HEAR IT IN

Back to Black – Amy Winehouse (pattern 1)

The swung 'down, down-up' bar, then a bar that runs through beat 3 and stops, leaving beat 4 silent.

62 Shuffle with space *swing feel*

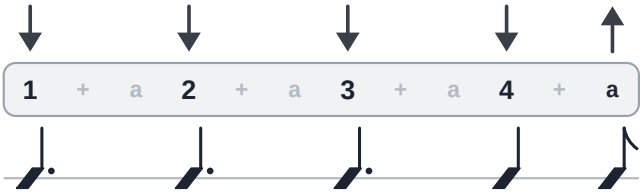


HEAR IT IN

Holiday – Green Day • Happy Together – The Turtles • Wagon Wheel – Old Crow Medicine Show • Sweater Weather – The Neighbourhood

The shuffle with the 'a' of beats 1 and 2 left out: one strum on beats 1 and 2, shuffled down-ups on beats 3 and 4. The swung version of 'Two upstrokes' from level 2.

63 Swung quarters with a pickup *swing feel*

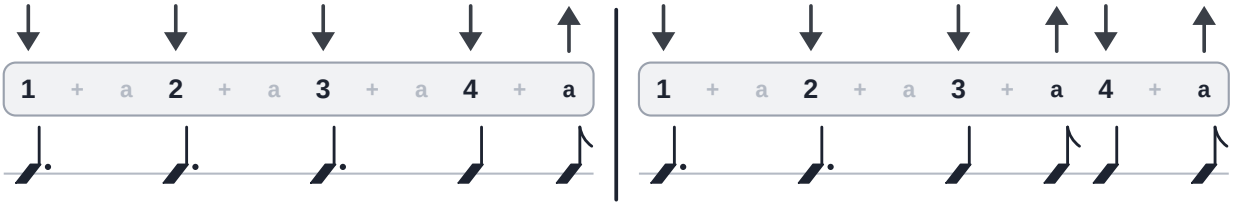


HEAR IT IN

Count on Me – Bruno Mars • God Only Knows – The Beach Boys (intro) • All I Want for Christmas Is You – Mariah Carey

Four strums on the beats and a single swung upstroke on the last 'a' to lead into the next bar.

64 Swung pickup bar, then shuffle with space *swing feel*

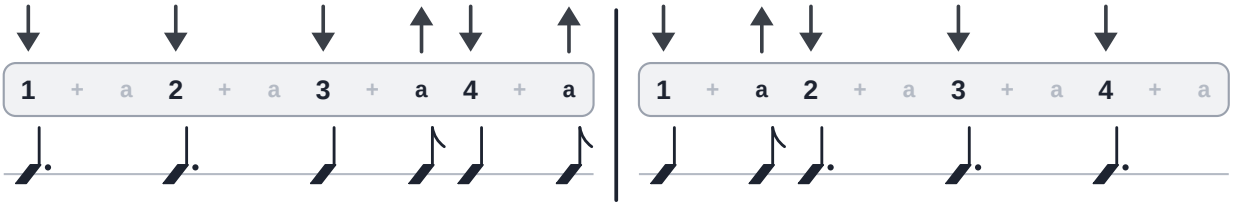


HEAR IT IN

The Weight – The Band (verse, line 1)

The previous pattern, then pattern 62: the second bar adds one more swung upstroke.

65 Shuffle with space, then the answer *swing feel*

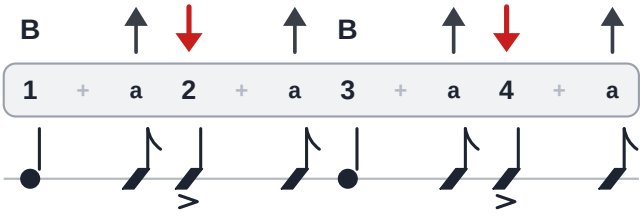


HEAR IT IN

Bad Moon Rising – Creedence Clearwater Revival (intro and verse, part 2)

Pattern 62, then the answer: one swung down-up on beat 1, then three plain strums.

66 Swung bass-and-strum *swing feel*

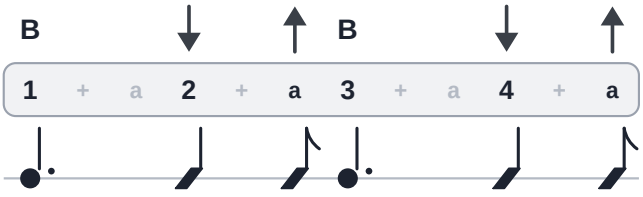


HEAR IT IN

A Horse with No Name – America • I'm Yours – Jason Mraz • Sweet Virginia – The Rolling Stones

Bass note on 1 and 3, strums everywhere else, all shuffled. Lean on beats 2 and 4.

67 Swung boom-chicka *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN

The Cape – Guy Clark • Rhubarb Pie – John Fogerty • Shame – The Avett Brothers

The previous pattern without the upstroke after each bass note: bass, down-up, bass, down-up, all swung.

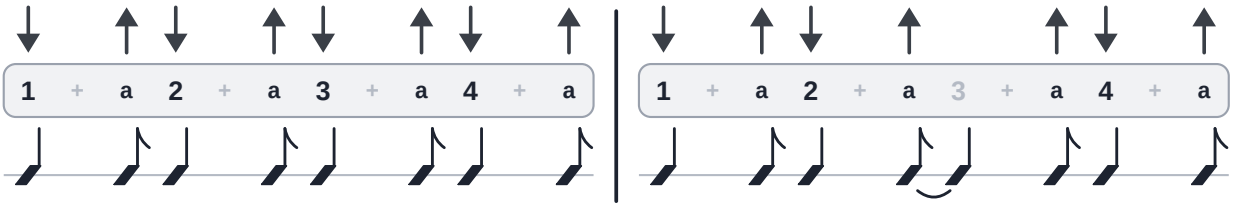
Level 6 - Syncopated triplets

The syncopated-eighth patterns of level 4, played with the triplet feel. A beat is skipped and the upstroke before it - now on the late 'a' of the triplet - hangs over the gap. If level 4 is solid, the hand already knows these; only the timing is new. The first pattern alternates a plain shuffle bar with a bar that misses beat 3, and the next two patterns each take one more strum away. The patterns after those are versions of the last of them: two-bar forms, a longer pause, a bass note and a tie across the bar line.

Skip a beat, swung level 4 with the long-short feel



68 Shuffle, then miss beat 3 *swing feel*

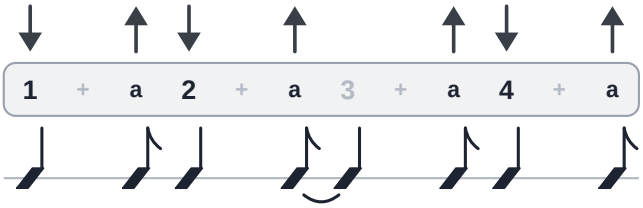


HEAR IT IN

Practice pattern – one missing strum, with a plain bar to recover in

One bar of the plain shuffle, then the same bar with the downstroke on beat 3 left out. The hand still moves down on beat 3; it only misses the strings. Loop the two bars until the gap stops pulling you off the beat.

69 Miss beat 3, swung *swing feel*

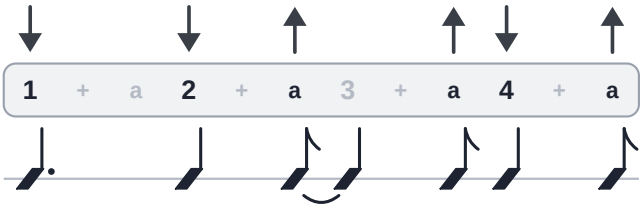


HEAR IT IN

Crazy Little Thing Called Love – Queen • Layla (Unplugged) – Eric Clapton (verse variation)

The second bar of the previous pattern on its own: a full shuffle with only beat 3 left out. Rockabilly rhythm guitar lives here.

70 Old Faithful, swung *swing feel*

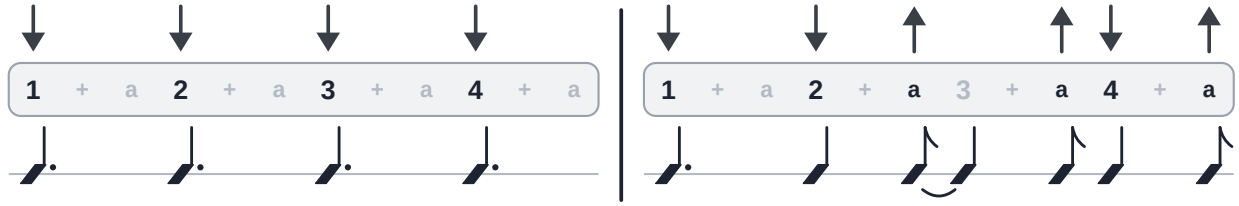


HEAR IT IN

With a Little Help from My Friends – The Beatles • You Were Meant for Me – Jewel • Happy Together – The Turtles • Wagon Wheel – Darius Rucker • Grow Old with You – Adam Sandler

The previous pattern with the 'a' of beat 1 left out as well, which makes it pattern 30 with a swing feel.

71 Swung quarters, then Old Faithful swung *swing feel*

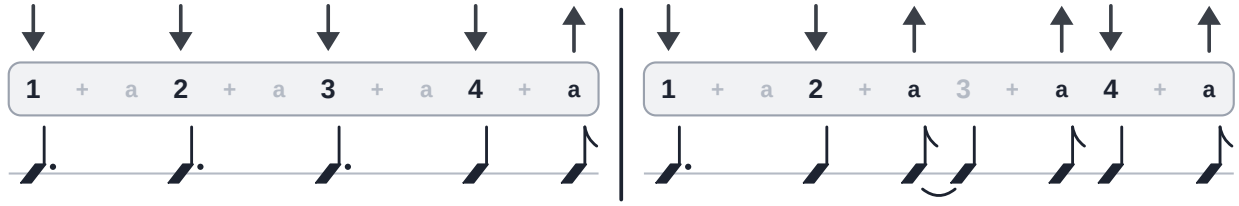


HEAR IT IN

Love Me Do – The Beatles

Four plain strums, then Old Faithful swung. The plain bar resets the beat before each syncopated one.

72 Swung pickup bar, then Old Faithful swung *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN

The Weight – The Band (verse, line 2)

The previous pattern with a swung upstroke at the end of the plain bar.

73 The long pause, swung *swing feel*

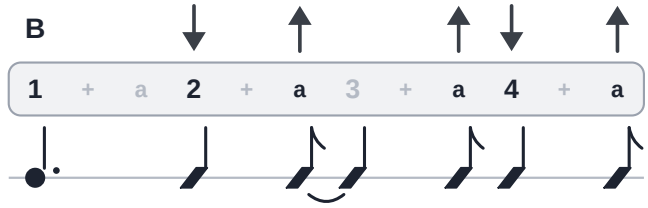


HEAR IT IN

Skinny Love – Bon Iver • Sweater Weather – The Neighbourhood (instrumental and bridge)

Old Faithful swung without the 'a' of beat 2: two strums, a long gap across beat 3, then a shuffled up-down-up to finish the bar.

74 Bass note, then Old Faithful swung *swing feel*

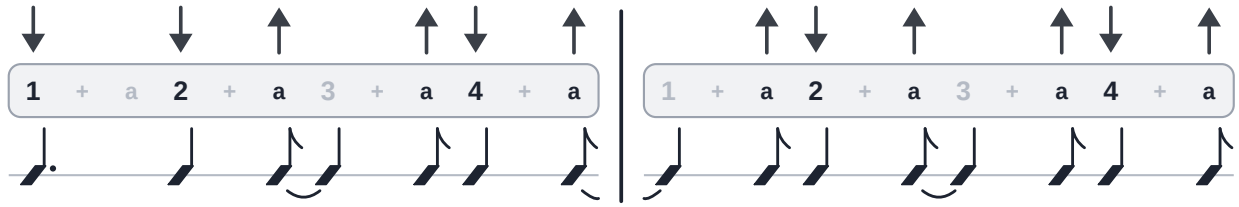


HEAR IT IN

Harvest Moon – Neil Young • Ripple – Grateful Dead

Old Faithful swung, with only the bass string on beat 1. The gentle country-folk lope.

75 Old Faithful swung, tied over *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN

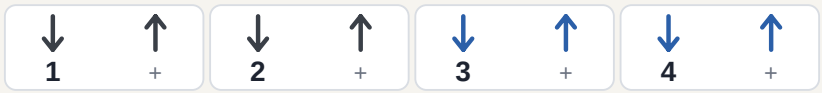
Death Bed (Coffee for Your Head) – Powfu

Pattern 44 with a swing feel: the downbeat of bar 2 is skipped and the last upstroke of bar 1 hangs over it.

Level 7 - Muting: left hand and right hand

Silence and 'chk' sounds are part of the rhythm. The left (fretting) hand mutes by letting go; the right (strumming) hand mutes by touching the strings. Same eighth-note motion as before - only the sound changes.

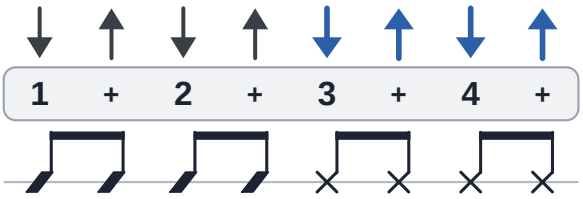
Left-hand mute let go of the chord: a dead chk



Right-hand mute the chuck: slap the strings on 2 and 4



76 Left-hand mute: ring, then choke

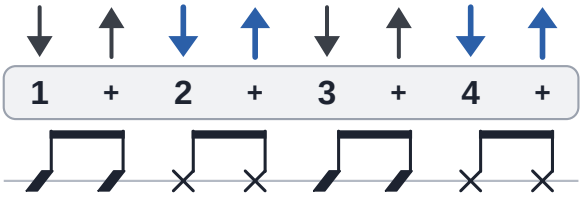


HEAR IT IN

Practice pattern – the basis of every percussive strum that follows

Left hand. Play two beats ringing, then release the pressure of the chord without lifting off - fingers stay touching, slightly flattened - and strum two beats of dead 'chk'. No pitch should sound. Squeeze again on beat 1.

77 Strum and scratch

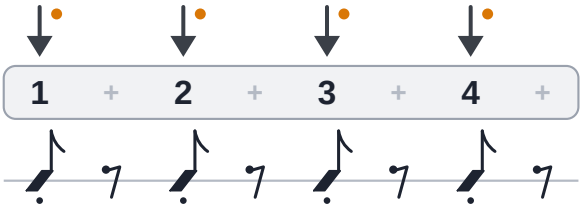


HEAR IT IN

Practice pattern – the left-hand mute on every second beat

Left hand. One beat of chord, one beat of scratch. The fretting hand pumps: squeeze, release, squeeze, release. Keep the strumming hand moving evenly; only the fretting hand changes the sound.

78 Staccato: strum and cut

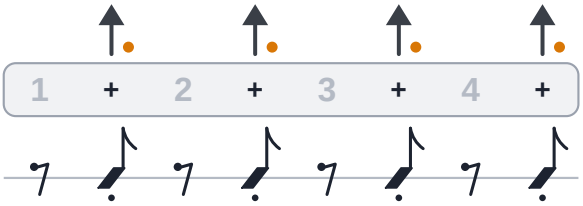


HEAR IT IN

Practice pattern – the same cut is used on the off-beats in the next pattern

Staccato means short. Strum, then kill the chord straight away so each strum is a clipped 'chop' with silence after it. With fretted chords, relax the left hand right after the strum (as in pattern 76, but after the chord has sounded). With open chords, drop the side of the right hand onto the strings instead.

79 Staccato off-beats *aka the reggae skank, ska upstrokes*

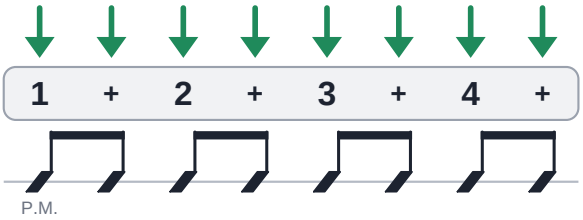


HEAR IT IN

Stir It Up – Bob Marley • Three Little Birds – Bob Marley

The reggae and ska 'skank': every beat is skipped and only the '+'s sound, each one cut short. Tap your foot on the beats or you will drift onto them.

80 Palm mute

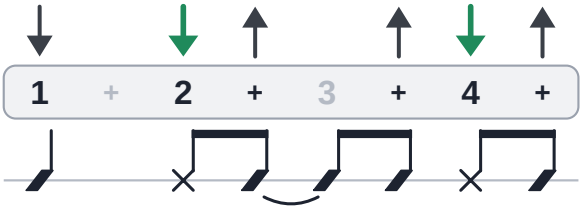


HEAR IT IN

Smoke on the Water – Deep Purple • Beds are Burning – Midnight Oil • Hot N Cold – Katy Perry • 1985 – Bowling for Soup

Right hand. Rest the edge of the palm on the strings exactly where they leave the bridge and play all downstrokes. You should still hear the notes, but tight and thuddy. Too far from the bridge and the note dies. Lift the palm for the chorus to open the sound up.

81 The chuck (Old Faithful with a slap)

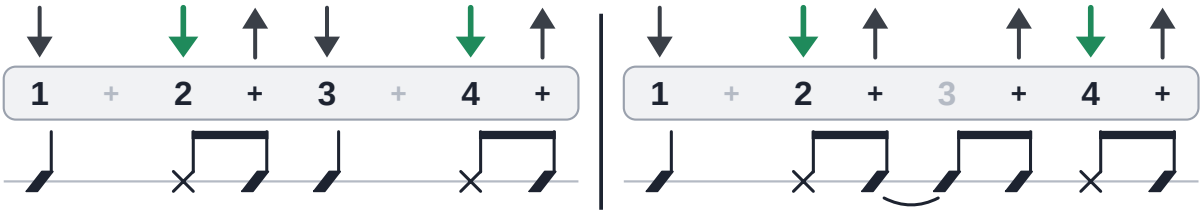


HEAR IT IN

Pumped Up Kicks – Foster the People • Sittin' on the Dock of the Bay – Otis Redding • Don't Know Why – Norah Jones • Speak Now – Taylor Swift • Flowers – Miley Cyrus (post-chorus and verse 2)

Also called: chunk, slap strum. Right hand. Pattern 30 again, but on beats 2 and 4 the palm lands on the strings at the same instant as the downstroke, giving a snare-drum 'chk'. The upstroke after it rings normally.

82 Chucks on 2 and 4, then the chuck strum

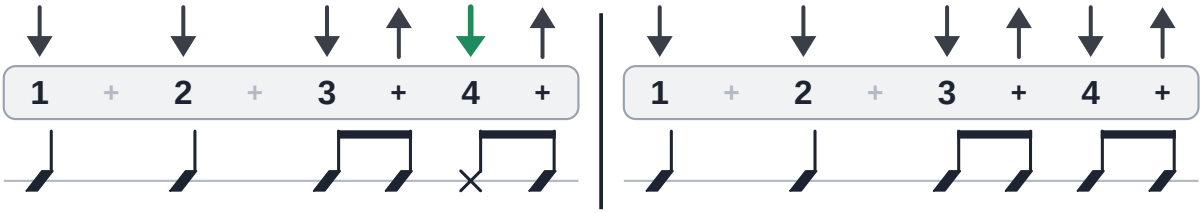


HEAR IT IN

What Makes You Beautiful – One Direction

Bar 1 is 'down, chuck-up' twice, with every beat played; bar 2 is the previous pattern, which skips beat 3.

83 One chuck, then none



HEAR IT IN

Mr. Jones – Counting Crows

Pattern 11 in both bars, with a chuck on beat 4 of the first bar only.

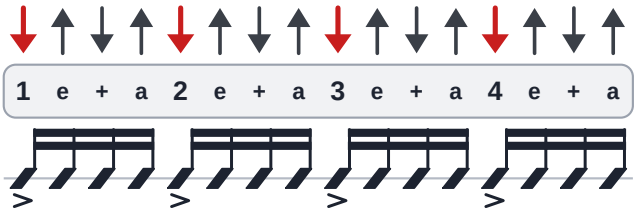
Level 8 - Straight sixteenth notes

Four slots per beat: '1 e + a'. The hand now moves twice as fast: down on the number and the '+', up on 'e' and 'a'. The level starts with all sixteen strokes and takes them away a few at a time, first the 'e's, then the 'a's, then the '+'s. Start at 60 bpm.

Four counts per beat down on the number and +, up on e and a



84 The sixteenth engine *aka straight sixteenths*

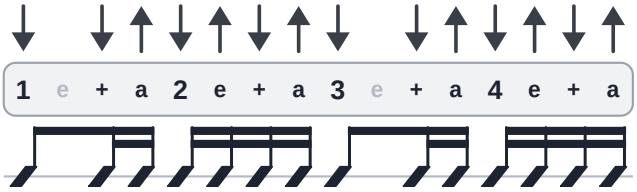


HEAR IT IN

Creep – Radiohead (second half of the chorus) • Lego House – Ed Sheeran

An exercise more than a song pattern: sixteen even strokes, accent on each number. Every pattern from here on is this motion with strokes left out.

85 Engine with a breath

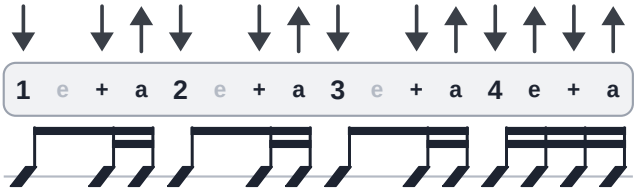


HEAR IT IN

Simple Man – Lynyrd Skynyrd (verse)

The engine with two strokes left out: the 'e' of beats 1 and 3. The hand still moves up there and misses the strings.

86 Gallop into a full beat

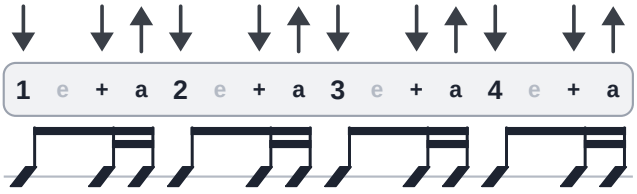


HEAR IT IN

Can't You See – The Marshall Tucker Band

The 'e' of beat 2 goes as well, so beats 1 to 3 are 'down, down-up' and only beat 4 is still a full four.

87 The gallop *aka galloping rhythm*

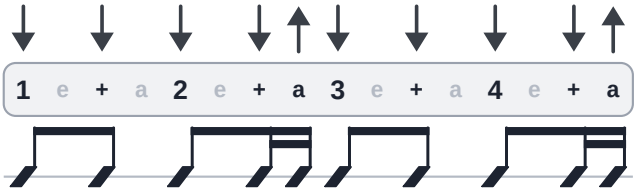


HEAR IT IN

Second Hand News – Fleetwood Mac • Crazy – Gnarls Barkley

Now every 'e' is gone. 'Down, down-up' on every beat: count '1 (e) + a, 2 (e) + a' with the 'e' silent - sixteenths, not triplets. Accent the number and it sounds like a galloping horse.

88 Indie-rock strum

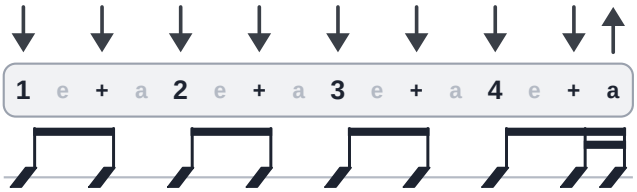


HEAR IT IN

Save Tonight – Eagle-Eye Cherry • D'You Know What I Mean? – Oasis • Dani California – Red Hot Chili Peppers (acoustic versions) • Let It Be – The Beatles • Knockin' on Heaven's Door – Bob Dylan • Ziggy Stardust – David Bowie • Boulevard of Broken Dreams – Green Day • Take Me to Church – Hozier

The gallop without the upstroke on beats 1 and 3: eighth-note downstrokes with a quick upstroke on the 'a' of 2 and of 4. The hand keeps the sixteenth motion throughout.

89 Eighths with a pickup

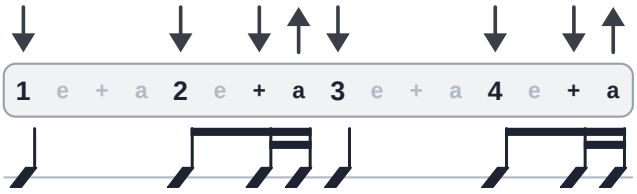


HEAR IT IN

Hey Jude – The Beatles • Eleanor Rigby – The Beatles • Beautiful – Christina Aguilera • Walk Away – Kelly Clarkson

Eight downstrokes on the numbers and '+'s, with one quick upstroke on the last 'a' of the bar. The indie-rock strum with only the last upstroke kept.

90 Slow strum with a flick



HEAR IT IN

Father and Son – Cat Stevens • Don't Look Back in Anger – Oasis • Angel from Montgomery – John Prine • Boulevard of Broken Dreams – Green Day (verses)

The indie-rock strum without the '+' of beats 1 and 3: one strum on beats 1 and 3, then 'down, down-up' on beats 2 and 4. The long strum lets the chord ring; the flick on the 'a' keeps it moving. A ballad staple.

91 Quarter notes with a flick

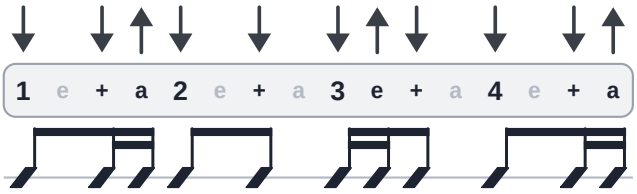


HEAR IT IN

Can You Feel the Love Tonight – Elton John • Angels – Robbie Williams • Alright – Pilate

One strum per beat, and 'down, down-up' only on beat 4. The sparsest pattern that still needs the sixteenth-note hand.

92 Gallop with a breath

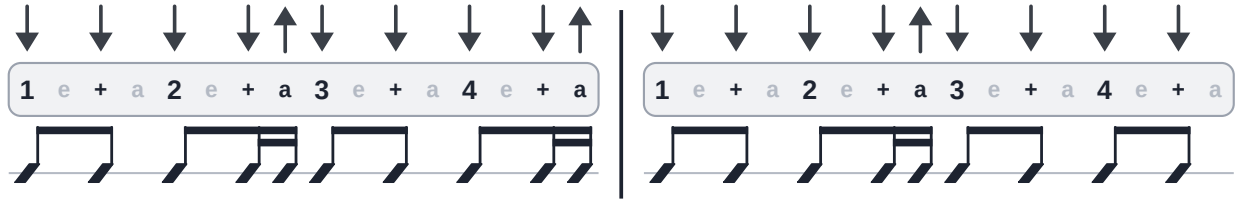


HEAR IT IN

Free Fallin' – Tom Petty • Teardrops on My Guitar – Taylor Swift

The gallop on beats 1 and 4 only: beat 2 is two plain eighths and beat 3 is 'down-up-down', so the bar breathes. Watch the '+' of 2: it is a downstroke with no upstroke after it, and beat 3 brings back the upstroke on the 'e'.

93 Indie-rock strum, then without the last flick

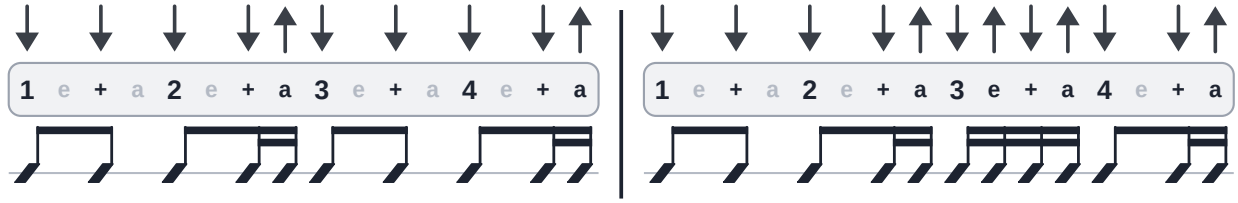


HEAR IT IN

Starman – David Bowie (intro)

Pattern 88 twice, leaving out the final upstroke of the second bar so the pair comes to rest.

94 Indie-rock strum, with a run

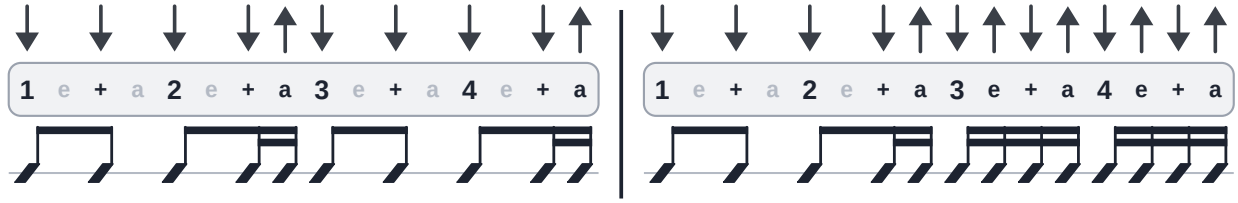


HEAR IT IN

No Surprises – Radiohead

Pattern 88, with a run of sixteenths through beat 3 of the second bar.

95 Indie-rock strum, then a long run

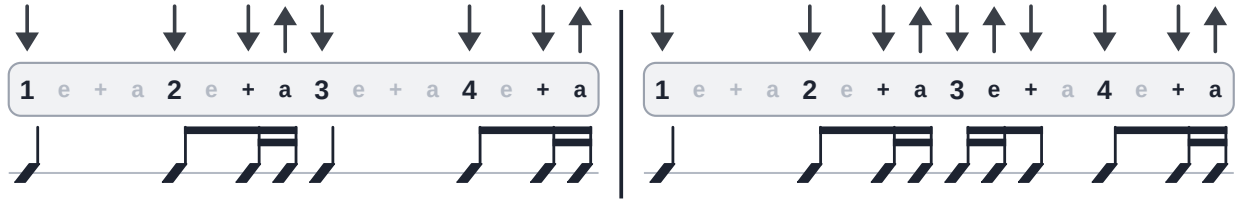


HEAR IT IN

Where Is My Mind? – Pixies (intro and verse)

As the previous pattern, but the run of sixteenths fills all of beats 3 and 4 of the second bar.

96 Slow strum with a flick, with a run

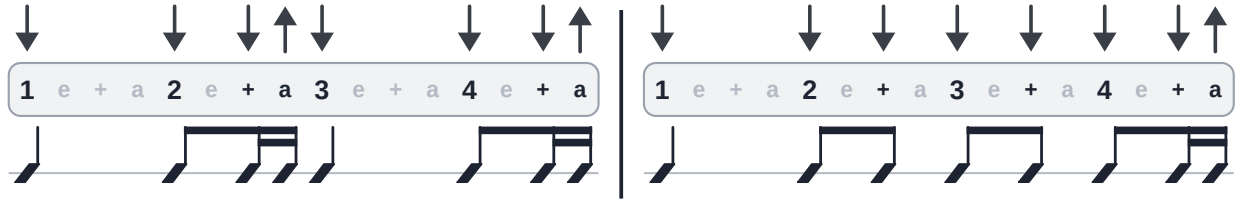


HEAR IT IN

Fake Plastic Trees – Radiohead

Pattern 90; the second bar fills beat 3 with 'down-up-down'.

97 Slow strum with a flick, then eighths



HEAR IT IN

For What It's Worth – Buffalo Springfield (chorus)

Pattern 90, then a bar that switches to steady eighth-note downstrokes from beat 2, with one flick at the end.

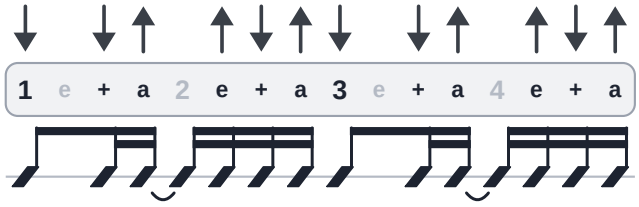
Level 9 - Syncopated sixteenth notes

The same trick as the syncopated eighths, one size smaller: skip the downstroke on a beat or on an '+' while the hand keeps its sixteenth-note motion.

Skip a beat Old Faithful at double speed



98 Old Faithful, double time

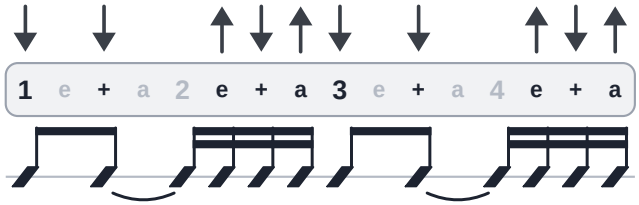


HEAR IT IN

Good Riddance (Time of Your Life) – Green Day • Someone Like You – Adele (chorus)

Pattern 30 squeezed into two beats and played twice per bar. Beats 2 and 4 are skipped; you come back in on the 'e'. Good Riddance adds bass-note picking.

99 The long pause, double time

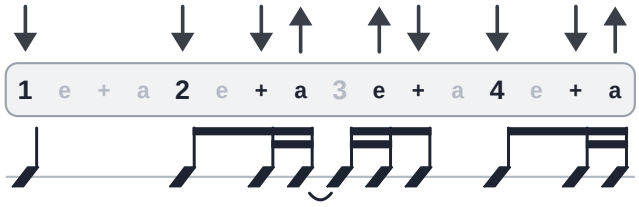


HEAR IT IN

Don't Think Twice, It's All Right – Bob Dylan

The long-pause strum from the syncopated eighths, played twice per bar. Beats 2 and 4 are silent, and so is the 'a' before them.

100 Slow start, skip beat 3

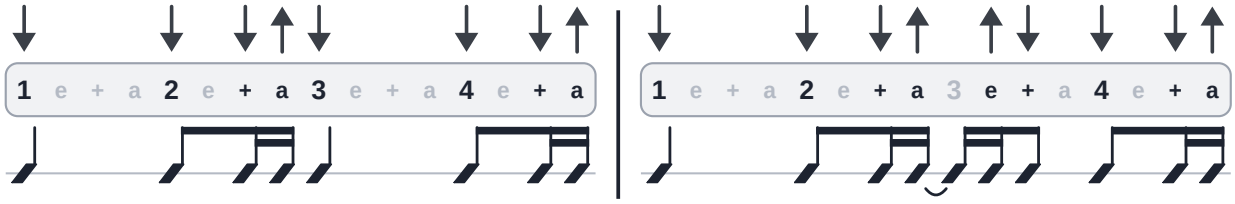


HEAR IT IN

Three Little Birds – Bob Marley • One – U2 • Travelin' Soldier – The Chicks • Time to Pretend – MGMT

A long strum on 1, 'down, down-up' on 2, then the upstroke on the 'a' of 2 hangs over beat 3. Only one beat is skipped, which makes this the gentlest syncopated sixteenth strum.

101 Slow strum with a flick, then skip beat 3

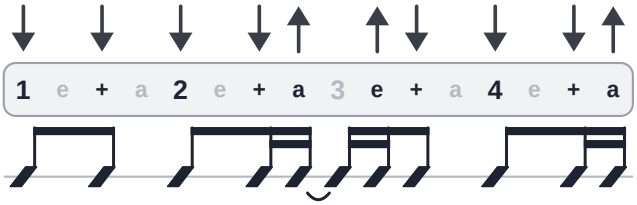


HEAR IT IN

TV – Billie Eilish

Pattern 90 from level 8, then the previous pattern. The two bars differ only on beat 3: played in bar 1, skipped in bar 2.

102 Skip beat 3

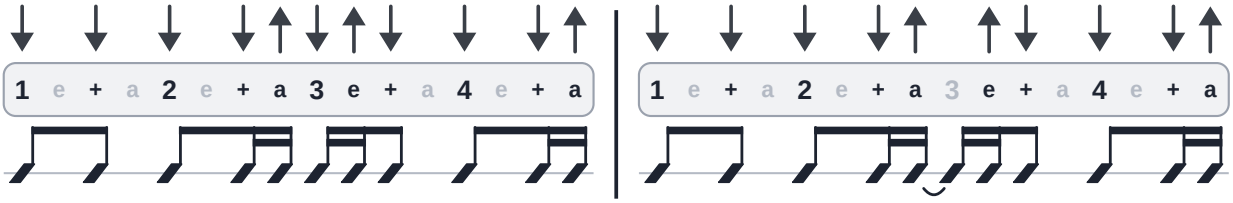


HEAR IT IN

Knockin' on Heaven's Door – Bob Dylan • Price Tag – Jessie J • Fireflies – Owl City • I Will Remember You – Sarah McLachlan • Sunny Came Home – Shawn Colvin

The indie-rock strum with beat 3 missed. The 'a' of 2 pushes across the middle of the bar and you land again on the 'e' of 3.

103 Fill beat 3, then skip it

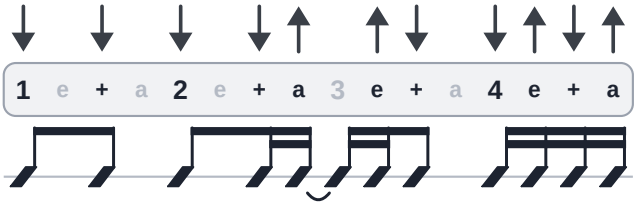


HEAR IT IN

Starman – David Bowie (verse)

Bar 1 plays down-up-down through beat 3; bar 2 is the previous pattern, with the downstroke on beat 3 left out.

104 Skip beat 3, busy ending

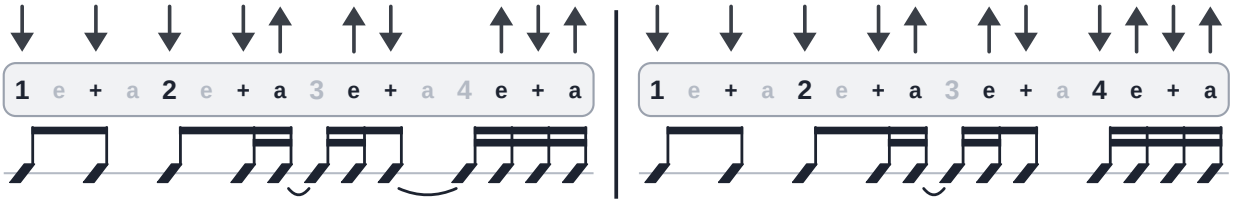


HEAR IT IN

Fast Car – Tracy Chapman (strummed arrangement) • Into the Mystic – Van Morrison • A Million Dreams – Ziv Zaifman, Hugh Jackman and Michelle Williams (from The Greatest Showman)

Pattern 102 again, but beat 4 fills up: 'down, down-up-down-up'. The run at the end drives into the next bar.

105 Skip beat 3, two endings

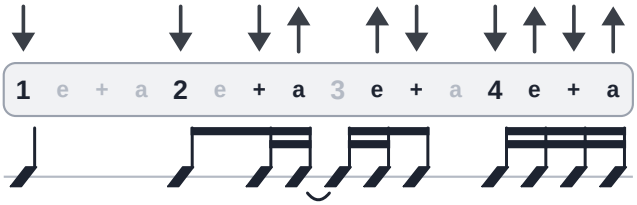


HEAR IT IN

Zombie – The Cranberries (intro)

Both bars skip beat 3. The first ends 'up-down-up' after a gap, the second is the previous pattern.

106 Slow start, busy ending

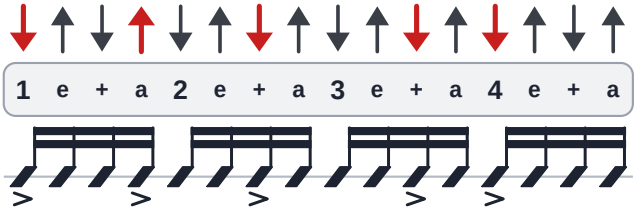


HEAR IT IN

Purple Rain – Prince • Scar Tissue – Red Hot Chili Peppers

Long strum on 1, skip beat 3, run of four on beat 4. Lots of space early in the bar, lots of motion late.

107 The Bo Diddley beat *aka 3-2 clave, hambone*

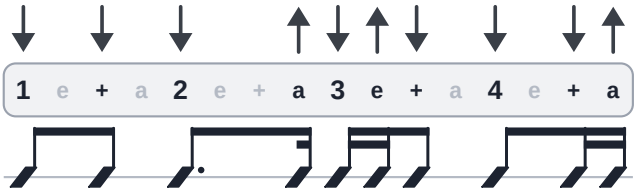


HEAR IT IN

Bo Diddley – Bo Diddley • Not Fade Away – The Rolling Stones • I Want Candy – The Strangeloves • Magic Bus – The Who • (Marie's the Name) His Latest Flame – Elvis Presley

Keep all sixteen strokes going lightly and hit five of them hard: 1, the 'a' of 1, the '+' of 2, the '+' of 3, and 4. Say 'bomp, ba-bomp-bomp ... bomp, bomp'. Many players mute the light strokes with the fretting hand so only the accents ring.

108 Modern acoustic strum

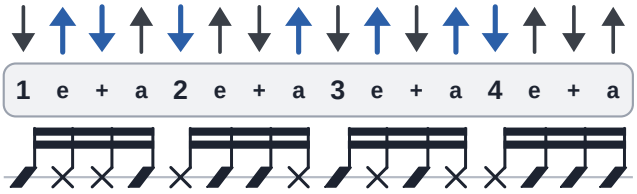


HEAR IT IN

Live Forever – Oasis (acoustic version) • Next step: Wonderwall – Oasis (the last pattern of this level)

The Britpop acoustic sound. The 'a' of 2 leads straight into beat 3 - learn beats 2-3 on their own first. Wonderwall is built from the same vocabulary; one two-bar reading of it is pattern 110.

109 Funk sixteenths with scratches

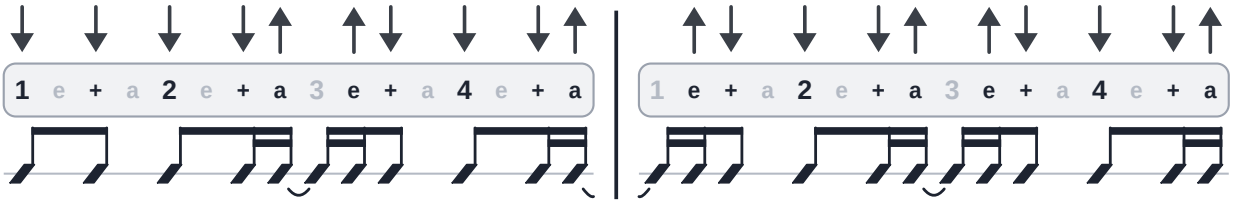


HEAR IT IN

Play That Funky Music – Wild Cherry • Le Freak – Chic • Let's Dance – David Bowie • We Are Family – Sister Sledge • I'm Coming Out – Diana Ross

Also called: chicken scratch. A typical funk figure, not a transcription - every funk song has its own. All sixteen strokes are played: the dark ones are the chord, the blue ones are left-hand mutes (pattern 76). Use small chord shapes on the top strings and let the fretting hand do the rhythm.

110 Skip beat 3, tied over



HEAR IT IN

Wonderwall – Oasis

Pattern 102 for bar 1; in bar 2 the downbeat is skipped as well, so the pattern is pushed across both the middle of the bar and the bar line. This is one teacher's reading of Wonderwall; other transcriptions differ in detail.

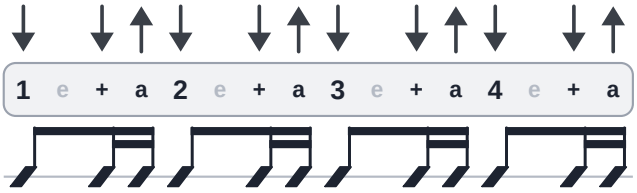
Level 10 - Swung sixteenths

The same long-short feel, one size smaller: every pair of sixteenths is swung. Most are sixteenth-note patterns of levels 8 and 9 with a bounce, so they come last.

Every pair long-short the sixteenths with a bounce



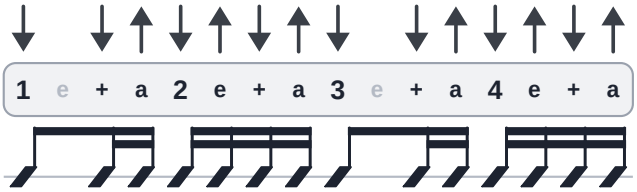
111 The gallop, swung *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN
7 Years – Lukas Graham

Pattern 87 with each 'down-up' pair played long-short. Start slowly: the bounce disappears if you rush.

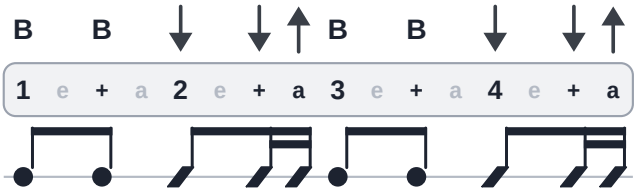
112 Swung sixteenths *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN
Hey, Soul Sister – Train

Down on the beat, then a run of swung sixteenths. The hand keeps the straight-sixteenth motion; only the timing bends.

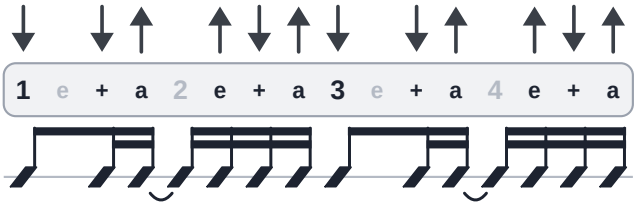
113 Bass notes and a swung flick *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN
Bubbly – Colbie Caillat • Wasting Time – Jack Johnson

Two bass notes, then 'down, down-up' with the last pair swung. Relaxed acoustic pop.

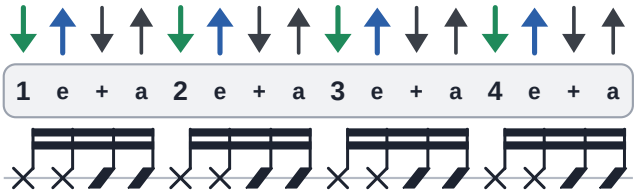
114 Old Faithful, double time and swung *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN
Hey, Soul Sister – Train (simplified)

Pattern 98 with a swing feel: beats 2 and 4 are skipped and the sixteenths bounce.

115 Swung chucks *swing feel*



HEAR IT IN
I'm Yours – Jason Mraz

Every beat starts with a muted down-up - a chuck on the beat, then a dead upstroke with the fretting hand relaxed - and ends with a ringing down-up, all swung. The strumming hand never stops; the fretting hand squeezes and releases once per beat.

About the songs

A strumming pattern is a teacher's reading of a recording, not a fixed fact: players vary the strum from bar to bar, sections differ, and lessons often simplify. Some pairings are a teacher's strummed arrangement of a song that has no strummed guitar on the record. The song pairings come from guitar-lesson and tab sites and were not checked against the recordings. Treat each song as a place where the pattern fits and can be heard, then let your ear refine it.

© 2026 Pedro Santos. Text and diagrams are licensed CC BY-SA 4.0. This is version 11, made on 12 November 2026. The latest version, with a click track for every pattern, is at https://pedromsantos.github.io/strumming-ladder/ Corrections are welcome: https://forms.gle/QZPsvZBsGkCLgS7t7